ALLENTOWN

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FADE IN

OPENING CREDITS:

The credits glide over a celluloid collage of 1950s Americana. Crisp, vintage reels paint a Norman Rockwellian tableau: idyllic families, pristine white picket fences, imposing homes nestled in amicable suburbs. It's the epitome of post-war prosperity, the American Dream incarnate. Suddenly, a voice slices through this nostalgic tranquility: RONALD REAGAN, distinct and authoritative.

RONALD REAGAN (V.O.)
I regret to say, we are in the worst economic mess since The Great Depression.

SMASH CUT TO:

EXT. ALLENTOWN, PA - 1982

Reality shatters the dream. Scars of urban decay pockmark the cityscape: plywood windows, derelict factories, faded "CLOSED" signs. It's a ghost town draped in rust.

RONALD REAGAN (V.O.)
We just had back-to-back double digit inflation. The last time this happened was in World War One.

He speaks over more shots of the city in ruin: Empty stores. Union Protests outside of closing factories. Desperate people in desperate times.

EXT. SUBURBAN HOUSE - DAY

RON KISTLER (25) wears battered overalls as he brandishes a paintbrush against the exterior of a weathered suburban house. He embodies 1980s boy-next-door charm with blonde hair and a matching mustache. A hand radio perched on a windowsill serves as his solitary companion, its speakers reverberating with the last few lines of Reagan's address.

RONALD REAGAN (O.S.)
Your standard of living is going down.

As the President's words fade into the background, a sprightly jingle rises:

"WSAN In The Morning"

The enthusiastic voice of GENE WERLEY (40s) a radio host for the local WSAN station, plays through the crackling static.

GENE WERLEY (O.S.)
Good morning, Allentown! That was President Reagan's address to the nation last night and I, of course, am Gene "Early" Werley here from WSAN, your new home for top forty hits. I hate to pile on, but unemployment just hit another all-time high and the once mighty Bethlehem Steel, which used to employ half of our beloved Lehigh Valley, is dying a not so slow death.

Ron keeps painting in silence.

EXT. STRIP MALL - DAY

DALTON YOUNG (22), walks out of an unemployment center and lights up a joint. He has a small mop of hair on his wiry frame. He puts on his aviators and blows smoke in the direction of the poor saps lined up at the Recruiting Office next door.

Dalton pounds his fist on the chest of his Army bomber jacket then throws up a peace sign.

DALTON YOUNG
Semper Fi, boys.

MAN IN LINE
That’s Army, not Marines.

DALTON YOUNG
It's all the same when you're back on this side.

A PRETTY GIRL walks by.

DALTON YOUNG (CONT’D)
Hey there, got plans tonight?

PRETTY GIRL
That depends, you got a job?

Dalton grins.

DALTON YOUNG
I've got character, isn't that enough?

She looks him up and down.

PRETTY GIRL
Not in this economy.

His shoulders slump.

INT. LOCAL BAR - DAY

MIKE MACKAY (31) takes a swig of his beer and returns his intense focus to the house of cards he's building on the bar top. He is bearded, stocky and always needs to be the center of attention. As he holds the final card above the tower he peers up at the BARTENDER.

MIKE MACKAY
If I can keep this guy up for three minutes will you comp me a beer?

BARTENDER
No chance in hell, Mike.

MIKE MACKAY
After all the business I've given you?

RONALD REAGAN
(on TV)
Here is a dollar such as you earned, spent or saved in nineteen-sixty...

BARTENDER
You've been nursing that bottle for two hours. I'm not running a charity.

Mike looks around at the DRUNK REGULARS.

MIKE MACKAY
Kinda looks like it.
(shouting)
Am I right, boys?

A regular rolls his eyes. They're tired of Mike's schtick.

RONALD REAGAN
(on TV)
...and here is a quarter, a dime and a penny. Thirty-six cents. That's the current worth of your dollar.

Linda pushes through the front door and scans the room. She spots Mike still holding court with the regulars, a fresh drink in his hand.

LINDA MACKAY
There you are.

His wife LINDA MACKAY (29), is worn out from a hard life, but still supports her husband as best she can.

LINDA MACKAY (CONT'D)
Let's head home, it looks like you've had a long day.

Mike tosses some dollars on the bar and follows her out.

MIKE MACKAY
Stay strong, boys.

INT. CAR - HIGHWAY - DUSK

Linda sits behind the wheel of a weathered car. Mike sits beside her.

LINDA MACKAY
It's sweet of you to support your friends like that.

MIKE MACKAY
Oh yeah, they love me. I'm like Bob Hope entertaining the troops. Kinda got me thinking about getting back into performing.

He lets the statement hang there. They ride in silence until the blast furnace stacks of Bethlehem Steel come into view in the distance.

LINDA MACKAY
When I was a little girl the sounds of those blast furnaces would keep me up at night. And I remember my mother telling me that those sounds are a good thing. It means people have jobs and we're all okay. And if there's ever a night that we don't hear them anymore, then we'd have something to be upset about. We're better off than most people Mike because we still have jobs. I don't know what more you're looking for.

MIKE MACKAY
I just feel like there's an opportunity for something bigger out there.

LINDA MACKAY
Look at us. Where do you think that opportunity's going to come from?

They continue to drive in silence.

INT. WSAN RADIO STATION - MEETING ROOM - DAY

GORDON OPLINGER (45) and MATT KRASJA (mid-30s) are locked in a heated exchange. Oplinger is a no-nonsense manager who believes he's better than the work he's doing and dresses accordingly and Krasja is the exact opposite, a brash showman in the fanciest suit a WSAN Allentown marketer's budget can buy him and the slickest hair the '80s will allow.

OPLINGER
A billboard sitting contest? Really Krasja?

KRASJA
You asked me to bring attention to the station's switch from country to the Unforgettable format.

OPLINGER
And your mind immediately jumped to "depression-era competition."

KRASJA
Unemployment's sky-high and we're giving the winner a free home. A home we don't have to pay for by the way. Everybody in Lehigh Valley's going to be talking about this and visiting the billboard. And when they do they'll see our station plastered all over that puppy.

OPLINGER
A billboard is a good idea, human beings eating and shitting on top of one is not.

EXT. WSAN RADIO STATION - DAY

A 1937 Rolls-Royce Phantom III, the same car Goldfinger drove, pulls up to the front of WSAN radio, a nondescript building befitting an AM station in the early 80s. HAROLD FULMER (42), a tall, heavy-set man with two McDonald's bags under his arm emerges, cigar in mouth, and puts on a 10-gallon hat.

INT. WSAN - DAY

As Fulmer barrels through the station every employee ducks out the way, desperate to avoid eye contact. This is the kind of presence Fulmer has spent decades cultivating and one he greatly appreciates.

He comes face to face with JANICE (60s), WSAN's receptionist, holding a styrofoam cup of coffee. Seasoned and grilled from her years at the station, she's one of the few people who couldn't give less of a shit about Fulmer's presence.

JANICE
Gordon and Matty are in the conference room.

MUFFLED YELLS can be heard through the thin walls.

FULMER
Sounds like they got started without me.

JANICE
You can say that. Coffee?

FULMER
I would love one.

He reaches for her cup. She motions across the hall before going back to her desk.

JANICE
Pot's over there.

Fulmer chuckles to himself. Janice's attitude towards him has also made her one of the few people to earn his respect.

INT. WSAN RADIO STATION - CONFERENCE ROOM - DAY

Fulmer walks in and tosses the bags of McDonald's on the table between the two men.

FULMER
Lunch is served.

OPLINGER
Do you just walk into the back and fill these up?

FULMER
I don't believe in handouts, even for the owner, so I always pay full price. Now tell me why I'm here?

Krasja bursts into pitch mode, waving his hands like a showman.

KRASJA
Picture it: Harold Fulmer, a man of the people who pulled himself up from nothing to become the business scion of Allentown, pays it back by offering an opportunity for one lucky local to earn a free luxury prefab modular living space from Love Homes. "You'll Love To Live With Us."

Oplinger registers how well Krasja's pitch lands with Fulmer and jumps to cut him off.

OPLINGER
He's trying to give a mobile home to a hobo.

KRASJA
It's not a mobile home. It's a luxury prefab modular living space. And they aren't hobos, they're loyal listeners.

OPLINGER
This contest is a brand clash. Three people living in tents on a billboard to win a mobile home appeals to poor rednecks. Which would be perfect if we were switching to country music and not away from it.

KRASJA
We already have a signed contract with Love Homes. We've spent weeks developing the rules, securing permissions from the township and the billboard is fully paid for.

OPLINGER
And what if one of these vagrants falls off and breaks his neck?

Fulmer looks to Krasja.

KRASJA
Full liability waivers. Fulmer himself could climb that billboard and choke a contestant to death and it would be considered an "Act of God."

Fulmer grins. Even though Oplinger's known him longer, Krasja has figured out how to appeal to the man's ego.

OPLINGER
Harold, when you offered me this GM role you promised me complete operational control of the station.

Fulmer looks back and forth between the two men while considering his decision.

FULMER
The contest is a go. Have Early Werley announce it first-thing tomorrow, catch people when they're on their morning commute.

Oplinger throws up his arms as Krasja smiles through a mouthful of Big Mac.

FULMER (CONT'D)
This is good for the rebranding, we'll get some quick press and the whole thing will be over before you know it. Honestly, who in their right mind can live on a billboard for more than a week?

INT. DALTON'S BEDROOM - DAY

Two hands carefully light a candle and then grip the ends of a headband. Dalton bring the band to his head and gently fastens it around his forehead like a martial artist.

He stands stoically in his underwear, smoking a joint and listening to Stargazer by Rainbow. As the music hits a CRESCENDO, he pulls out his nunchucks and starts swinging them around in a semi-choreographed mess.

INT. DALTON'S HOUSE - KITCHEN - DAY

DALTON'S MOM (44) cooks breakfast in the kitchen as Gene Werley gives his morning broadcast.

GENE WERLEY (O.S.)
Mortgage interest rates just hit eighteen percent, folks. Eighteen percent!

DALTON'S MOM
Dalton! Do you want some scrapple?

No answer. She throws some scrapple in the pan.

GENE WERLEY (O.S.)
With the cost of owning a home too high, how would you like to win one instead? Wouldn't that be nice? Well now you can. This is no joke, folks. This is a one-of-a-kind contest.

Dalton's mom looks down at the radio, intrigued.

INT. WSAN RADIO STATION - BOOTH - DAY

Gene Werley sits at the studio mic reading from the copy in his hand.

GENE WERLEY
We're teaming with our friends at Love Homes, You'll Love To Live With Us, to give away one luxury prefab modular living unit made with cutting-edge NASA technology...

He raises his eyebrows to the PRODUCER on the other side of the glass.

GENE WERLEY (CONT'D)
... Valued at eighteen-thousand-dollars, to whichever one of our listeners can live the longest on top of a billboard.

EXT. STEEL PLANT - DAY

Ron Kistler walks down the street, resume in hand. As he approaches the Steel Plant he sees the group of picketers outside. He takes a moment and then turns back.

EXT. MANUFACTURING PLANT - OFFICE DOOR - DAY

Ron tries the door but it's locked, he peers in the window where a SHOP MANAGER on the phone sees him and waves him away, pointing to a sign on the door. Ron checks it.

"Not hiring. Do not leave contact info."

GENE WERLEY (O.S.)
This dream can become your reality. All you have to do is jot down in twenty-five words or less why you want to enter the contest and drop your entry at the station.

INT. DALTON'S HOUSE - DAY

Dalton's mom puts Donahue on mute to listen to the radio.

GENE WERLEY (O.S.)
There is no limit to the amount of times you can enter and the three names will be drawn randomly. So come down to WSAN and show us how badly you want it.

Dalton's Mom excitedly runs up the stairs.

INT. MIKE'S CAR - DAY

Mike and Linda drive down the highway. She stares out the window in a trance at the mundane drive, part of their every day routine. Mike is fixated on the radio.

GENE WERLEY (O.S.)
We already have the billboard just off Route Twenty-Two, now all we need are three lucky men to battle the elements, and each other, for their new home. Love Homes. You'll Love To Live With Us.

Mike's eyes light up.

MIKE
You hear that, Linds?

LINDA
What are yo--

He clocks where they are then quickly SWERVES into the next lane to hit the exit.

Mike's eyes light up. Linda watches him, already knowing what he's thinking.

INT. DALTON'S ROOM - DAY

Dalton's Mom bursts through the door of his bedroom. The Pretty Girl from outside the Recruitment Center lays nude in his bed. She SCREAMS and covers up as Dalton looks on, still in his undies and karate headband, wielding his nunchucks, bleary-eyed from the pot.

DALTON'S MOM
I'm going to enter you in a contest.

DALTON
Last time you signed me up for something I spent a year in Korea.

DALTON'S MOM
And all you got out of it was shin splints and an addiction to marijuana and easy women.
(to the Pretty Girl)
No offense, dear.

PRETTY GIRL
Oh, I'm not easy.

DALTON'S MOM
You just slept with an unemployed man who spends his free time getting high and doing naked karate in his mom's house.

PRETTY GIRL
Oh God.

DALTON'S MOM
(to Dalton)
I'm entering you into the contest. If you're going to be doing nothing all day you can do it on a billboard. And breakfast will be on the table in ten. For both of you.

ON SCREEN IN TYPEWRITTEN FONT: "I could live indefinitely on a billboard. - Dalton Young"

EXT. EMPTY RURAL LOT - DUSK

Ron and Sue perch on the hood of Sue's truck. They gaze over an expansive stretch of undeveloped land framed by towering trees that seem to blend with the horizon, all bathed in the dimming hues of twilight. The only thing missing is an actual house.

SUE
Are you sure this is a good idea? You cooped up in a loud place with other people?

RON
What's wrong with that?

SUE
You hate loud places and other people.

Ron smiles, acknowledging the truth of Sue's words.

RON
You're worth it.

Ron looks out at the vacant lot. Endless potential.

RON (CONT'D)
If I go up that billboard I'm not coming down without a house to put here for us.

They look out over their lot, imagining the life they could have together, before Sue breaks the silence.

SUE
So... your folks' place or mine?

ON SCREEN IN CAREFUL HANDWRITING: "Due to the high cost of living, I may never be able to purchase a home of my own. - Ronald Kistler"

INT. MACKAY APARTMENT - MORNING

Linda, still in her nightgown, enters the kitchen and finds Mike writing feverishly at the table. She kisses him on the head but he doesn't acknowledge her.

LINDA
What are you doing?

Mike slides a piece of paper over to Linda without looking up. She grabs it and looks at it.

LINDA (CONT'D)
You were serious about that?

MIKE
I'm surprised you're not more excited.

LINDA
I specifically married you because you don't live on a billboard on the side of the highway.

MIKE
This is the chance of a lifetime, Linda. You listen to the radio. You saw the President do that trick with the coins. If people with good jobs can't afford to buy a house right now what chance do we have? I'm built for this. It'll be an easy win. And this isn't just a home. It has cutting-edge technology. From NASA.

LINDA
And what about work?

MIKE
Told them I'd be gone for a few weeks and they agreed to hold my job as long as you pick up the slack while I'm away.

LINDA
It was nice of you to run a decision like that past me.

MIKE
Everybody's always lookin' past me. Once I'm on that billboard they won't be able to look away.

ON SCREEN IN A MESSY SCRAWL: "I Need A Home - Mike MacKay"

INT. WSAN - LOBBY - DAY

Mike bounds in and slams his single entry down on the desk of JANICE, the receptionist.

MIKE
Yes, ma'am.
(he awkwardly bows)
(MORE)

MIKE (CONT'D)
I would like to formally enter the hobo competition.

JANICE
Not bad, but a lady dropped off a thousand entries for her son earlier today.

MIKE
Son? You're letting kids into this thing?

JANICE
The way she talked about him he's either an adult or a well-trained house cat. And that gentleman you almost knocked over gave me this...

She kicks a box out from under her desk overflowing with entries. Mike goes wide-eyed and then squints, recognizing competition.

MIKE
How many?

JANICE
Said he was shooting for four-thousand and ended up four over. Go figure.

Mike is stunned. He turns with purpose and moves to the exit.

INT. WSAN - OPLINGER'S OFFICE - DAY

Krasja bursts through the door where Oplinger crunches numbers.

KRASJA
Six... hundred... thousand.

Oplinger looks up.

KRASJA (CONT'D)
That's how many entries we have for the billboard competition. Forty-seven-thousand from one guy alone.

OPLINGER
There's a lot of desperate people in Allentown.

KRASJA
And now they all know WSAN is the new home for top-forty. Admit it. This idea is a hit.

OPLINGER
Poor people don't have money. Which means poor people don't spend money. Which means I have to spend all day convincing advertisers that these people are not our new demographic and are a sad side effect of a charming snake-oil salesman peddling hope to the hopeless.

KRASJA
You really think I'm charming?

OPLINGER
Fuck directly off.

EXT. WSAN - DAY

A LARGE CROWD clogs the station's small parking lot. Gene sits at a makeshift DJ booth on the blacktop. A novelty "On Air" sign illuminated behind him.

GENE WERLEY
This is Gene "Early" Werley wishing you all a good morning on this special day. Because I'm coming to you live from the WSAN parking lot where, in just a few moments, we'll be selecting the three lucky men or women who will compete in our Love Homes Contest. Love Homes. You'll Love To Live With Us.

The crowd parts as Goldfinger's ROLLS ROYCE PHANTOM III glides into a reserved parking space at the front door. Harold pulls himself out of the driver's seat, puts on his cowboy hat and lights a cigar. He's greeted by Krasja who straightens his bolo tie.

FULMER
Showtime.

Two massive bags full of submissions are dumped on the stage, creating one huge pile. Mike unapologetically squeezes through Ron and Sue to reach the front of the stage. Ron lets it slide, never one to make a scene.

Linda stands several feet back.

Werley raises a hand and the crowd falls silent.

GENE WERLEY
Is everybody ready?

The crowd ROARS.

GENE WERLEY (CONT'D)
Ladies and gentlemen, I would like to welcome to the stage the CEO of Fulmer Industries, the owner of WSAN and the reason we are all here today. Mr. Harold G. Fulmer the Third.

The crowd APPLAUDS as Harold barrels onto the stage, waving and eating up the attention. Ron, Sue, Mike and Linda watch eagerly.

EXT. DALTON'S HOUSE - DAY

Dalton sits on a lawn chair with a cooler beside him. He reaches down, grabs a cold beer, cracks it open, turns on the small radio next to him and carefully tunes it.

EXT. WSAN - PARKING LOT - DAY

Gene adjusts the mic stand so it's at Harold's level and then opens one of the bags.

FULMER
Howdy and thank you all for coming out on this beautiful Pennsylvania day. A man's home is his castle. Which is why WSAN is pleased to partner with Love Homes to give three lucky contestants the chance to win their very own piece of the American dream.

The crowd eats it up. Harold paces across the stage like a rock star.

FULMER (CONT'D)
You want a home and you want a home, hell I got a home and I want one of these too. But we only have one fine American-made prefab modern marvel to give away.
(MORE)

FULMER (CONT'D)
Now ladies and gentlemen, I take great pleasure in unveiling what we've all gathered here for today: The Love Homes Deluxe Model H.

Krasja jogs on stage and whispers into Fulmer's ear.

FULMER (CONT'D)
Whazzat? Oh, sure. Love Homes. You'll Love To Live With Us.

Krasja gives a thumbs up to two SUITS in the audience. Fulmer waves his hand and a large red curtain drops to reveal a painted and finished prefab home perched on the back of a semi-wide tractor trailer. The home is immaculate, perfect, quintessential, done up to be the American dream home, complete with fake grass, some lawn chairs and a barbecue.

Mike and Ron look on with awe. Both are lost in their individual fantasies of what their lives could be. Fulmer pulls out some index cards.

FULMER (CONT'D)
Featuring two bedrooms, two baths and a whopping one-thousand-one-hundred-and-sixteen square feet of premium aluminum-clad living space using cutting-edge NASA grade technology.

As we push into the door of the home, a narrated tour begins. The camera floats through the home as Fulmer speaks. It is nowhere near as luxurious or spacious as his carefully-worded copy makes it sound. His narration does not match what our eyes see.

FULMER (CONT'D)
The master bedroom is straight ahead. With a queen-sized bed and shag carpeting, this home isn't prefab... it's prefabulous.

We quickly cut from the bedroom back to Fulmer, who fumbles with the index cards in his hands.

FULMER (UNDER HIS BREATH) (CONT'D)
Jesus Christ, who wrote this shit?

He flips through the remaining index cards before shoving them back into his jacket as Mike looks back to Linda and mouths the word "NASA."

FULMER (CONT'D)
All you have to do to win this lovely home is be the last one on that billboard. Whatever it takes.

Krasja jogs on stage again and whispers into Fulmer's ear.

FULMER (CONT'D)
Whazzat? Of course. Whatever it takes within the confines of the rules. Now let's get to it.

Harold makes a show out of the process. He puts one hand over his eyes and reaches into the pile. He selects an entry, opens his eyes, unfolds it and...

A DRUMROLL plays on the loud speaker.

FULMER (CONT'D)
Our first contestant is... "I Need A Home - Mike MacKay!"

Mike SCREAMS and jumps up and down as Linda tries to grab and hug him. He pulls free without turning back and bounds on the stage, finding a position next to Fulmer. He pumps his fists up and down.

FULMER (CONT'D)
Mike MacKay everybody. The second winner is... "I Need A Home- Mike MacKay."

Mike leans into the microphone.

MIKE
I'll gladly take both spots.

The crowd eats it up as Harold unfolds another entry. Glances at it and sighs.

FULMER
How many times did you enter, son?

MIKE
Forty-seven-thousand. My wife really wants me out of the apartment.

Another LAUGH from the crowd. Mike takes in the attention, enraptured with it, as Fulmer grabs another entry.

FULMER
Our second contestant is... Dalton Young.

EXT. DALTON'S HOUSE - DAY

Dalton lays passed out on the lawn chair. The radio next to him plays ROCK MUSIC from a different station.

EXT. WSAN RADIO STATION - DAY

The crowd is silent as everybody looks around for Dalton to claim his place on stage.

FULMER
Dalton? Dalton Young? Guess he had someplace more important to be.

The crowd LAUGHS as Fulmer reaches into the sack for another name.

Sue nervously glances at Ron who appears calm as ever. His hand tells a different story as his fingers form a tight grip around hers.

FULMER (CONT'D)
The final contestant is... Ronald Kistler.

RON
That's me, I'm Ronald Kistler.

FULMER
And is that Mrs. Kistler?

SUE
Not yet!

RON
Someday. Hopefully.

FULMER
Well not yet someday hopefully Mrs. Kistler, do you support Ron in this endeavor? Speak now or forever hold your peace.

Sue looks over to Ron.

SUE
I do.

FULMER
Perfect. Ladies and Gentlemen, I am proud to present... your Billboard Boys. Well, two of the three anyway.

The rapidly dispersing crowd half-heartedly CLAPS for the two men who took their spots in the contest.

EXT. DALTON'S HOUSE - DAY

Dalton's Mom explodes through the front door.

DALTON'S MOM
Dalton. We did it!

EXT. BILLBOARD - DAY

It's dreary. Three ladders rest up against the Billboard, leading to a platform about five feet deep and thirty feet across. Their new home.

Hanging from the center of the platform is a sign that reads:

"*We have been living here for '0' days*"

Dalton exits his mom's car and hoists his beat-up knapsack over his shoulder. He takes a drag of his cigarette while looking up at the billboard, bringing him shoulder to shoulder with Ron, also looking up at the board. Ron nods.

DALTON
Yo.

At the base of the billboard Mike leans into Linda and smiles.

MIKE
Look at those baby-faced schmucks.
I'll see you in a few days.

Sue kisses Ron on the cheek as Mr. Kistler motions him over.

MR. KISTLER
Ronald, it took me three years of savings just to put a down payment on the house you grew up in. Right now you've got an opportunity that won't come around twice. So if you ever think about climbing down that ladder, you give me a call and we'll have a chat.

RON
Yes sir.

Dalton's Mom gets emotional as she hugs her son goodbye.

DALTON
You can visit anytime, mom. I'll always be home.

Mike, Ron and Dalton approach the base of the board and stand alongside Harold and Krasja. The crowd is considerably smaller than the one gathered for the drawing. There are a couple local reporters.

Harold leans into Krasja.

FULMER
I expected a bigger turnout.

KRASJA
Probably the rain. At least the people who matter are here.

Krasja motions to the camera crews filming.

NEWSREEL FOOTAGE: Local news outlets interview the three contestants one at a time in the field with the billboard in the background.

REPORTER
Are you excited to be chosen for the competition?

MIKE
As a natural athlete and vigorous outdoorsman I feel this contest plays to all of my strengths.

DALTON
I thought my mom was joking about entering me. Since I left the army I haven't been able to get a job, but they trained me to sit in a tent and do nothing for long periods of time so I feel pretty good about my chances.

RON
(deadpan)
I am beyond ecstatic. This is an incredible opportunity and one of the greatest moments of my life.

REPORTER
And what is your strategy for winning and walking away with that brand new home?

MIKE
I've got a long list of ways to get those guys off the billboard and nothing but time.

DALTON
The Army trained me in a style of psychological warfare that has not yet been disclosed to the public.

RON
(deadpan)
I imagine my path to victory is by staying on the billboard for longer than Mr. MacKay or Mr. Young.

EXT. BILLBOARD

The men all stand at the base of a ladder.

FULMER
(to the crowd)
Everybody ready? Gentlemen, take your places.

Ron looks back to his parents and Sue and gives them a stern nod. His father nods back.

FULMER (CONT'D)
In five... four...

Dalton gives a half-ass military style salute to his mom and flicks his cigarette to the ground before stamping it out.

FULMER (CONT'D)
Three... two...

Linda looks to Mike, but Mike is busy mugging for the cameras.

FULMER (CONT'D)
...one. Welcome home!

Mike never looks back to Linda and climbs the steps faster than Ron and Dalton. All three carry bags on their backs. Upon reaching the platform, the men approach the front railing, smiling and waving.

Linda glances over at Sue. Their eyes meet. No smile or wave.

KRASJA
Hey Ron, change the sign.

Ron leans down. The sign now reads:

"*We have been living here for '1' days*"

THUNDER strikes in the distance as rain begins to fall around them. The men watch as the media circus wraps up and the crews pack up their equipment. As the vans pull away we see Sue and Linda, coats over their heads, quickly make their way to their cars.

The media circus that made them the center of attention only minutes ago is already gone to look for its next story, leaving the valley empty and the guys all alone as rain begins to pour on them.

All that remains are three men on a billboard.

EXT. BILLBOARD - DUSK

The billboard has no physical dividers so the three station-supplied tents are spaced equally apart. Mike on the left, Ron in the middle and Dalton on the right. Each man has a portable toilet, a radio, a phone and whatever supplies they packed.

The sun sets behind the mountains in the distance. There's a steady WIND that causes the billboard to sway slowly back and forth. Lights turn on automatically, illuminating the board, as the three men lean against the railing of the billboard watching the cars ZIP by on the highway below. If the silence was ever going to be broken, it would be by Mike.

MIKE
Either of you guys got an extra blanket. If I don't cover my head with something these lights are gonna keep me up all night.

DALTON
I have several extra blankets, because I'm prepared for any situation.

Dalton ducks into his tent.

MIKE
Aw, thanks man.

A long silence before it becomes clear.

MIKE (CONT'D)
He's not coming back out, is he?

Ron just shrugs.

INT. DALTON'S TENT - NIGHT

Dalton illuminates the competition rulebook with the lighter he simultaneously lights a joint with. Right under the light is the clause outlawing drugs and alcohol. He grins as he takes a long, slow drag.

INT. MIKE'S APARTMENT - NIGHT

Linda arrives home and tosses the keys onto the table. She looks around. Nothing but darkness and silence.

INT. SUE'S HOME - NIGHT

Sue sits around the dinner table with her parents, holding hands around a meal saying grace.

INT. DALTON'S HOUSE - NIGHT

Dalton's Mom dances around the kitchen, SINGING at the top of her lungs.

INT. WSAN STUDIO - MORNING

Gene Werley is live on air.

GENE WERLEY
I can confirm that our three contestants did make it through their first night. They're up there right now above the billboard. Sure gives a new meaning to "lofty living," eh? So why don't you give us a ring and share your thoughts or give some advice to the boys.

Gene looks expectantly at the call switch. Nothing.

GENE WERLEY (CONT'D)
Would you consider it a room with a view or the world's worst studio apartment?

Still nothing.

GENE WERLEY (CONT'D)
Okay... welp... I'll be here all morning.

EXT. BILLBOARD - MORNING

Ron bends down and switches the sign to "2" with a toothbrush hanging out of his mouth. He stumbles as he stands back up and the toothbrush falls out of his mouth, through the grate flooring and onto the dirt below. Mike notices and conceals a laugh.

MIKE
Maybe Dalton has an extra one he can pretend to lend you.

Dalton emerges from his tent and takes a piss off the side of the billboard, not awake enough to notice he's flashing the cars traveling down the I-22 freeway.

Mike begins doing some loose stretches. Dalton sees and in one bow, bends straight down and grabs his toes. Mike grimaces and then starts doing jumping jacks. Dalton eyes him down and removes his shirt, showing his military physique, then does picture-perfect jumping jacks. In the middle of this, Ron tries to ignore the spectacle. Mike grabs his duffel with one hand and begins hurling it up above his head.

MIKE (CONT'D)
Always been more of a power-lifter myself.

Dalton nods then jumps up and grabs one of the steel beams above them, doing pull-ups with ease, the morning sun glistening off his abs. Mike drops his duffel in defeat.

EXT. BILLBOARD - NIGHT

Sue, still in her factory cafeteria uniform, approaches the board. Linda sits in a chair beneath Mike's side. The two ladies ignore each others' presence. Dalton has some friends on his side playing LOUD MUSIC from a boom box. Ron lowers a bucket as Mike strums some chords on a guitar.

MIKE
I gotta tell you, honey. I slept like a baby up here last night. I could use a little jerky maybe. And my magic stuff. But other than that, I'm golden.

Sue loads up Ron's bucket with food.

SUE
How are you holding up?

Ron looks down, points to his ear and shakes his head.

SUE (CONT'D)
I asked how you're holding up.

Ron thinks.

RON
Could use a new toothbrush.

A larger crowd begins to grow as cars filled with young men and women pull up, seeming to have found their new hangout.

SUE
I think I'll head home before it gets too rowdy.

MIKE
(eyeing the crowd)
You know what, Linda. You should get home as well. I really need as much shut-eye as I can get.

EXT. BILLBOARD - MUCH LATER

A RAGER beneath them, the men watch as the growing group of onlookers has morphed into a drunken party.

CROWD
(chanting)
Billboard Mike! Billboard Mike!

Mike hops up on the railing and balances like a surfer to the CHEER of the crowd.

MIKE
Toss me a beer, boys!

A can flies up and he catches it, regaining his balance just before he can fall to the ground.

DALTON
Is it going to be like this every night?

Car horns HONK from the highway. The men turn to see a car filled with people stopped in the center lane, hanging out the window and waving to get the guys' attention.

A truck skids and SLAMS into the back of the car, sending it sliding into another lane and SIDESWIPING a passing car into the ditch.

RON
I hope not.

A metal can FLIES past Mike's head and sends him toppling backwards.

MIKE
(shouting down)
Not cool, guys.

Ron inspects the projectile.

RON
It's spam.

MIKE
(wiping himself off)
They couldn't at least try to kill me with some turkey chili?

Dalton takes the can from Ron.

DALTON
We lived off this stuff in basic training.

RON
You were in the army?

Dalton squints and moves to his tent, having already shared too much.

MIKE
Hey, that's mine.

Mike grabs Dalton by the arm to prevent him from getting into his tent.

DALTON
Get off me, man.

RON
Let's maybe calm this down a bit.

MIKE
Stay out of my business.

Dalton shoves back at Mike, but his grip is firm on the arm of Dalton's jacket.

CROWD
FIGHT! FIGHT! FIGHT!

MIKE
You think if I toss you off this billboard you can army roll to safety?

Ron gets in-between them.

RON
They'll disqualify all of us if we lay hands on each other.

DALTON
I'll warn you once to get off me.

MIKE
Or what?

Dalton SPINS, removing his jacket in Mike's arms, and dives back into his tent, emerging with his NUNCHUCKS. Mike jumps back and grabs his GUITAR from the other side of the billboard. Ron stands in the middle helpless as the two CHARGE each other, weapons RAISED.

Out of nowhere a 737 DESCENDS rapidly overhead and makes the whole billboard SHAKE VIOLENTLY, knocking all three men off their feet. Dalton turns and HURLS the can as far into the distance as he can.

DALTON
There. Problem solved.

With the tension sucked from them, all three men return to their respective parts of the billboard.

EXT. BILLBOARD - DUSK

The signs reads: "*We have been living here for '6' days*"

Ron sits in silence with Sue in her folding chair below him as Dalton tosses down an empty beer can to his friends.

DALTON
Take this with you when you go, we're not supposed to have booze up here.

DALTON'S FRIEND
That's lame. Here, catch.

He tosses up another can which Dalton opens with a pop.

INT. BILLBOARD - MIKE'S TENT

Mike lays on his cot speaking into his phone.

MIKE
I feel like these guys are already starting to crack. Ron's girlfriend has been here every day and just stares up at him like a lost puppy dog.

INT. MIKE'S APARTMENT - INTERCUT

Linda lays on the couple's bed holding the phone to her ear.

LINDA
And how about you?

MIKE
I'm doing great.

LINDA
It's been a tough week, Michael. The work is hard without you but being here, alone, is harder. I don't want to be a downer but if I feel like this after six days what's it going to be like if this really does last a month?

MIKE
No chance. Trust me, I would much rather be laying beside you.

LINDA
I had a dream about you last night.

MIKE
Oh yeah?

LINDA
I was wearing that thing you liked from our honeymoon. I unbuttoned your shirt and--

INT. MIKE'S TENT - NIGHT

A phone RINGS from somewhere on the billboard. Mike listens as Linda continues talking.

RON (O.S.)
I appreciate you taking the time to call but I'm not interested in giving a quote for your story.

MIKE
Gotta go, honey.

He tosses the phone down.

INT. RON'S TENT - NIGHT

Mike BARRELS in and grabs the phone from Ron.

MIKE
Billboard Mike here. I'll gladly talk to you about my experience.

INT. MIKE'S APARTMENT - NIGHT

LINDA
Hello? Mike?

A dial-tone in Linda's ear, leaving her defeated and alone.

EXT. BILLBOARD - NIGHT

The three men mind their own business on a rare peaceful night on the billboard. Mike STRUMS some chords on his guitar. Dalton meditates with his nunchucks in hand and Ron leans on the railing looking out at the stars.

A can FLIES through the air, narrowly missing Ron's head before SLAMMING into the billboard behind them. Ron picks it up.

MIKE
Spam or beans?

Ron and Dalton reluctantly look over to Mike.

MIKE (CONT'D)
Well shit, we have to talk at some point. Spam or beans?

Ron looks at the can.

RON
Spam.

MIKE
Again? I think they're just trying to hit us at this point.

Another can FLIES past Ron's head. He looks out at THREE DRUNKS standing in the field. Dalton shouts down at them.

DALTON
Throw us something useful for a change.

They wait in silence until a magazine flies up onto the billboard, not quite making it. It lands open on the railing. It takes the boys a moment to process what they're seeing. Directly in front of them are the prying eyes of Morgan Fairchild seducing them from the October edition of PENTHOUSE MAGAZINE.

They all lunge for it at the same time, but the magazine falls off and plummets into the overgrown grass below. On its way down it passes the sign.

"*We have been living here for '19' days*"

EXT. PAYPHONE - DAY

A frustrated BETSY MORRIS (25) taps her head against the glass. She is a grinder who always pays attention to the tiniest details that elude those around her.

EDITOR (V.O.)
The copy's not the problem. You say things are shit in Allentown?

BETSY
They are.

EDITOR (V.O.)
Worse than all the other shit in the country?

BETSY
It is.

EDITOR (V.O.)
Then dig deeper. Make it resonate. If you can't, pack up and we'll send you to the next economic disaster zone.

Betsy hangs up and looks around the depressed street. She hears Mike's voice BOOMING from a nearby radio.

INT. WSAN RADIO STATION - HALLWAY - DAY

Oplinger catches Krasja in the hall.

OPLINGER
It's day thirty. We guaranteed Love Homes thirty days of promotion. What happens now?

KRASJA
We agreed to operate in good faith.

OPLINGER
How many more days do you think they have in them?

Krasja shrugs and keeps walking.

INT. PLANT - DAY

Sue wheels a cart around the cafeteria of one of Allentown's few surviving and operating manufacturing plants. As she picks up the trays of turkey and mashed potatoes and throws away the cheap Thanksgiving decorative paper into her bin, she notices the TV in the corner of the room. She smiles at the sight of Ron, but the smile is pulled from her face as she overhears the workers speak.

MAN
Look at these clowns.

WOMAN
Like a bunch of kids living in a treehouse.

Sue fights off the urge to confront them.

MAN
It's embarrassing that people associate Allentown with that circus. We have enough problems as it is.

He motions to the TV where Mike clowns around for the camera.

MUSIC CUE: "ALLENTOWN" BY BILLY JOEL

EXT. BETHLEHEM STEEL - DAY

Images of the towering Bethlehem Steel blast furnaces align with the two opening steam blasts of Billy Joel's Allentown.

EXT. ALLENTOWN - DAY

We see slices of life, including people sitting on porches and talking over coffee, families playing in their yards, Allentown's locals being happy in the face of endless financial peril.

EXT. BILLBOARD - DAY

Over the lyrics "Well we're living here in Allentown and they're closing all the factories down" Ron leans over the front of the Billboard and changes the sign to:

"*We have been living here for '71' days*"

EXT. BETHLEHEM STEEL - DAY

Over the lyrics "Out in Bethlehem, they're killing time, filling out forms, standing in line" picketers pace outside of Bethlehem Steel.

INT. SUE'S HOME - DAY

Over the lyrics "Well, our fathers fought the second World War, Spent their weekends on the Jersey Shore" Sue carefully packs food and places it into a bag with a copy of American Rifleman.

INT. DALTON'S HOME - DAY

Over the lyrics "Met our mothers at the USO, Asked them to dance, danced with them slow" Mrs. Young folds Dalton's clothes while watching the report on television.

INT. HOTEL ROOM - DAY

Over the lyrics "And we're living here in Allentown, but the restlessness was handed down" Betsy writes over and over again, struggling to find her way into the story.

INT. MIKE'S TENT - DAY

Over the lyrics "And it's getting very hard to stay" Mike scrapbooks with articles of himself from the papers.

EXT. POND - DAY

Fulmer stands knee-deep in the pond, dressed in full fishing gear, whipping his rod deep into the pond. Oplinger stands next to him in a full suit with mud-boots covering his shins. About twenty feet away stands a GRANDFATHER with his GRANDSON, fishing together as Allentown plays over their radio on shore.

FULMER
I wish the song showcased a little more of Allentown's positive side instead of making it all out to be doom and gloom.

OPLINGER
There are people living on a billboard to combat the housing crisis. Hard to argue its accuracy. Speaking of which, WSAN was flat last month while York and Lancaster grew. The billboard isn't driving ad revenue because advertisers don't want to sell to poor people.

FULMER
It's a conundrum.

OPLINGER
It really isn't. It's time to end it, Harold.

FULMER
Not yet. I have a feeling this thing is going to catch fire.

OPLINGER
The only way it catches fire is if one of these bums falls asleep with a cigarette in his mouth and burns the whole fucking thing to the ground. It's our responsibility to get them down.

The Grandfather looks over disapprovingly at Oplinger and leads his Grandson away.

FULMER
Responsibility is a funny thing, Gordon. Most men never live up to theirs, they shirk it. That's the problem with America today.
(MORE)

FULMER (CONT'D)
"Responsibility." Across this great land, bars are filled with men who drown their sorrows with excesses and excuses. Guys who feel no compunction about denying the responsibility they were given as Americans to try and make something of themselves. They spit in the face of what makes this country great and squander the opportunity at their feet.

OPLINGER
Those mobile homes cost eighteen-thousand a piece and Love Homes would sell them to us wholesale. Think of the marketing potential. We'd come out looking like saints. "WSAN and Harold Fulmer make the American dream a reality for three blue collar guys." Let's give them each a home and put an end to this.

Fulmer's demeanor changes as he begins to anger.

FULMER
Everybody talks about chasing the American dream, but nobody remembers what that actually means. In America if you want something you need to earn it and the American dream is getting the opportunity to do that. Those men are up there right now earning their God damned future and you want me to give them a handout? This is why Allentown is in shambles. A bunch of people lining the streets with their hands out asking those of us who push the pedal day in and day out to open our wallets. I don't believe in handouts, I believe in hand ups. Those men out there, they're not just sitting on that billboard, those fellas are fighting for something. That's beautiful and I won't take it away from them. We're teaching these men to fish, Gordo.

His rod catches and he reels it in.

EXT. STREET - DAY

Betsy walks down the street until she sees a HIPPIE smoking in his van, listening to the radio.

BETSY
Mind if I bum one?

The Hippie hands over a smoke and a light.

HIPPIE
Not from around here?

BETSY
What gives it away?

He points at her outfit, too chic.

HIPPIE
You a city gal.

BETSY
You got me. I used to dress to blend in but I've found people are more willing to open themselves up if I look professional.

HIPPIE
Probably cause when you look like yourself people don't think you're trying to trick 'em.

She hears Mike's voice BOOMING from the radio.

MIKE (V.O.)
Dalton's the army guy, Ron's the quiet guy and I'm the handsome, charismatic one. But they only entered five-thousand times combined while I entered ten times that much. Which means if we each had a third chance of winning, my third would be equal to ten times their thirds combined, giving me ten-thirds to their one-third. And ten-thirds is three and a-third. Which means I win three times for every time either of them wins. So yeah, I'm not worried. The odds are in my favor.

The Hippie laughs.

HIPPIE
Man, I love these guys!

BETSY
Who are they?

HIPPIE
These are the dudes the radio station makes live on their billboard.

BETSY
I'm sorry, the what?

She turns up the man's radio.

EXT. BILLBOARD - DAY

The sign on the front of the billboard reads: "*We have been living here for '78' days*"

Mike sits in front of his tent reading.

MIKE
You guys should read this. Brilliant author. He's been called the voice of his generation.

RON
I'm good with my magazines, thanks.

Dalton drops to do pushups and right below his face is a copy of Cooking Varmints and Other Little Critters by Mike MacKay.

MIKE
Don't worry. Had the missus drop off some extra copies.

Dalton slides it out of the way and notices something on the ground below him. He can just barely make it out by peering between the grates, but right below is Morgan Fairchild staring up at him. The Penthouse is weathered but in tact, down there, unnoticed by his competitors.

EXT. BILLBOARD - DAWN

Break of sunup, Dalton emerges from his tent holding a long stick with a wad of chewing gum on the end. He threads it through the grate, fishing.

MIKE
What're you doing?

Dalton panics. Mike's eyes follow the stick to the ground, sees the magazine. His eyes go wide.

DALTON
Aw shit.

Mike quickly pulls off his shoelace and begins to tie it to the end of his guitar, his own makeshift rod.

Ron exits his tent and looks at Mike and Dalton, both on their stomachs, fishing their contraptions through the grates.

DALTON (CONT'D)
I saw it first.

MIKE
This is billboard life. Up here it's every man for himself.

DALTON
You have a wife, this is all I got.

MIKE
I'm trying to keep this filthy smut out of the hands of today's impressionable youth.

Ron peers through the crack to see what they're after then nods knowingly.

RON
Makes sense.

MIKE
You gonna stand around gawking or are you going to help?

RON
I do kinda want to read that article on competitive bowhunting.

He grabs the back of Dalton's spear for support.

DALTON
Mike's getting in the way.

MIKE
My lace is wrapped around your rod.

RON
If we took the two tools and combined them maybe we--

BETSY
(calling up)
Am I interrupting something?

The three men look down at Betsy. She clutches a pad close to her chest as she braces the cold.

BETSY (CONT'D)
What are you guys up to?

DALTON
Mike, what are we up to?

MIKE
Ron?

Ron thinks.

RON
Arts and crafts?

Mike and Dalton stare at Ron.

BETSY
Do you need a hand?

ALL THREE
No!

They quickly pull up their contraptions and toss them behind their tents.

BETSY
Sure is cold out here.

RON
December in Pennsylvania.

BETSY
You're Ron, right?

RON
Yes ma'am.

BETSY
And you're Mike?

MIKE
Everyone calls me Billboard Mike.

DALTON
Nobody calls you Billboard Mike.

MIKE
It's only a matter of time.

BETSY
My name is Betsy Morris and I'm covering the economic situation in Allentown with Bethlehem Steel shutting down. It looks like you three have a unique perspective on the situation. Do you mind if I ask you some questions?

They motion to a ladder on the ground.

EXT. BILLBOARD - DAY

Betsy tries to make herself comfortable on a bucket with the three guys sitting across from her.

BETSY
Why put yourself through this? It all seems so torturous, freezing on a billboard on the side of a highway all for a chance at a home.

RON
It's not a chance, it's a promise.

BETSY
I don't understand.

RON
Each of us had a chance at being selected. After that we were promised a new home as long as we don't come down. That's why there were six-hundred-thousand entries. This is the only option left for most of us.

MIKE
I told my wife it would be two weeks tops before I got these guys off of here. But apparently they need this just as bad as I do.

One of the billboard phones rings behind them.

BETSY
What's that?

DALTON
The station calls us to do promos and interviews. Apparently we're quite popular.

BETSY
And what do you get in exchange for these promotions?

MIKE
What do you mean?

BETSY
Any compensation for advertising the radio station?

The men stare blankly as Betsy scribbles furiously on her note pad.

RON
Which paper do you work for again?

Betsy looks up.

BETSY
The Wall Street Journal.

EXT. BILLBOARD - NIGHT

Two ladders prop up against the edge of the billboard. Dalton pops his head out of his tent where Mike and Ron stand eagerly.

DALTON
What's with the ladders?

RON
We already told you.

MIKE
Tonight's conjugal visit night.

He raises his eyebrows to Dalton.

DALTON
And I told you guys I don't know what that word means.

He sees Linda and Sue, both made up and dressed like they're hitting the town, climb up on the ladders. He still doesn't quite know what's going on.

INT. DALTON'S TENT - NIGHT

Dalton lays back staring straight up at the roof of his tent as the billboard shakes. His eyes are wide open at the sounds of the GIGGLES and MOANS from the other tents.

INT. RON'S TENT - NIGHT

Ron and Sue cuddle and hold each other in the tight sleeping bag.

SUE
It's hard without you.

RON
Say the word and I step down.

SUE
I know you would. I also know you want to start a life together as badly as I do, and we can't do that on a twin-bed in our childhood bedrooms. As much as I love sleeping next to your Farrah Fawcett poster.

RON
Don't think that poster's not coming with us.

She playfully shoves him and they hold each other tight.

RON (CONT'D)
Soon. I promise you that.

INT. MIKE'S TENT - NIGHT

While laying close together, the distance between Mike and Linda is ever present.

LINDA
How much longer, Mike?

MIKE
These jerks'll be off the moment snow falls.

LINDA
Not that. With you. With us. How much longer of Billboard Mike before I get my Mikey back?

MIKE
I am your Mikey and I'll always be your Mikey. I'm up here so we won't have to worry about rent on the first of every month.

LINDA
These are days together that we'll never get back. I wish I was enough for you.

MIKE
Linda. You are everything to me.

He says it, but neither of them believe it.

LINDA
I really, truly hope you're up here for the right reasons.

EXT. BILLBOARD - NIGHT

Snow falls on Allentown.

Ron weatherproofs his tent as Mike leans against the side of the billboard STRUMMING his guitar. Dalton pokes his head out of his tent, smoke pouring out around him.

Dalton looks up at the snow that comes down around them and flinches as a flake hits his face.

DALTON
This city is hell on Earth.

MIKE
You don't like Allentown?

DALTON
Why do you think I joined the army?

MIKE
Punitive recruitment?

DALTON
I'd sooner have gone to jail.

Mike STRUMS a few chords.

MIKE
You’ll end up there sooner or later.

DALTON
First thing I'm going to do when I get down is hit up Andre's for a cheesesteak.

There's silence. This is the longest conversation the guys have had. Ron goes against his every instinct and decides to keep it going.

RON
I've never been.

Dalton looks over in shock.

DALTON
You kidding me? Andre's? Home of the Philly Cheesesteak?

Mike and Ron both shake their heads.

DALTON (CONT'D)
I'll tell you what. When I get down I'll treat you both to some Andre's.

RON
What about you, Mike? What are you going to do when you get off this billboard?

MIKE
I'm going to drive out to California to capitalize on this fame.

DALTON
I see it now... "Starring Debrah Winger and Billboard Mike."

RON
What's Linda think about that?

MIKE
You think she's going to complain about a mansion in the Hollywood Hills?

RON
Can't argue with that logic.

MIKE
But first I'm going to swing by Republic and grab a beer.

DALTON
Never heard of it.

MIKE
Russian bar hidden on the edge of the city. Very communist, so it's always empty. Cheapest beer in Allentown.

DALTON
What about you, Ron? What's the first thing you're gonna do when you get off this billboard.

Ron thinks about it.

RON
I'm going to take Sue to see our new home.

Another 737 flies overhead shaking the billboard and its sign:

"*We have been living here for '86' days*"

INT. WSAN - STUDIO - DAY

Gene broadcasts.

GENE WERLEY
Hard to believe there's just two weeks until the fat man in red makes his grand appearance and he'll need that warm suit and hat because it's getting awfully cold in the valley. Temperatures fell to single digits last night.

A YELLOW LIGHT flashes on the switchboard in front of him, signifying an incoming call. Then a second. Gene doesn't notice.

GENE WERLEY (CONT'D)
Yesterday a man drove a white van through Washington bearing the message "number one priority: ban nuclear weapons" in big bold letters to the base of the Washington Monument. He threatened to destroy the landmark with one-thousand pounds of dynamite unless a national dialogue was opened on the threat of nuclear war.

More yellow lights. Gene doesn’t notice the producer seated on the other side of the glass trying to get his attention.

GENE WERLEY (CONT’D)
After ten hours, he jumped in the van and started driving, threatening to become a moving time-bomb in downtown Washington.

Every yellow light is now illuminated. The producer is frantic. Gene struggles to keep focus then gives up and tosses his notes to the side.

GENE WERLEY (CONT’D)
Everything's fine, the cops shot him a bunch in the head. Now for a word from our sponsors.

Gene hits a button, takes off his headphones and quickly heads for the producer.

GENE WERLEY (CONT’D)
Every line's lit and I'm not giving anything away. What the hell's going on?

INT. WSAN - OPLINGER'S OFFICE - DAY

Oplinger sits at his desk going over some paperwork. Krasja bursts in and tosses the Wall Street Journal down in front of him.

KRASJA
You wanted a way to get your upper-crusts interested. How's that for elite?

Gordon looks down at the article on the front page. "Why 3 Grown Men From Pennsylvania Live on a Billboard" by Betsy Morris. Oplinger picks it up and skims the article.

OPLINGER
'Underhanded', 'profiteering', 'the worst aspects of American capitalism?' Did you even read this?

KRASJA
I don't need to read it, it's The Wall Street Journal. No way you're shutting it down now. We've gone national.

EXT. BILLBOARD - DAY

Ron, flanked by Mike, reads from a battered copy of The Wall Street Journal that was thrown up to them.

RON
The only thing worse than the exploitive nature of the competition, fashioned after the equally shameless flagpole sitter contests of The Great Depression era, is the fact that Ron, Dalton and the self-proclaimed Billboard Mike are seemingly unaware that they are being exploited by a greedy millionaire for his own gain. Not only is their desperate situation in this terrible economy being used against them, they are seen as free labor, told to promote the station at every possible turn.

MIKE
Holy shit...

The men let the article sink in.

MIKE (CONT'D)
I'm famous!

A news van pulls into the cloverleaf. A reporter and cameraman scurry to grab their equipment as a second van pulls in. Mike perks up as a third van pulls in.

MIKE (CONT'D)
It's about time.

Dalton emerges from his tent and begins to light a joint. He notices the commotion and immediately tosses the joint back in his tent.

INT. WSAN LOBBY - DAY

Chaos. Reporters pile into the small WSAN lobby. Janice is nonchalant in how effortlessly she handles the situation, holding the phone to her ear and repeatedly pressing a button on the base.

JANICE
Unforgettable 1470 WSAN, please hold.

EXT. BILLBOARD - DAY

Mike leans over the edge with a bucket on a rope as Linda fills it up with supplies. He pulls it up and looks through. Every move they make is filmed by the insane media circus that has yet to go away.

MIKE
(calling down)
These are all canned vegetables. Where's the chili?

LINDA
The news says heart problems and chili are linked.

MIKE
I don't have heart problems.

LINDA
You will if you keep eating chili.

Mike leans over and yells to the cameras below.

MIKE
She'll do anything to get me on a diet.
(to Linda)
Love you, honey.

On the opposite side of the billboard Dalton talks to DENNIS PETERS (20s), one of the regular party-goers, who holds up a six-pack.

DENNIS
Send down your line, man and I'll hook you up.

DALTON
Nice.

He throws down his bucket.

DENNIS
We grunts gotta look out for each other.

DALTON
You serve?

DENNIS
Got back from Korea earlier this year.

He scans the crowd.

DENNIS (CONT'D)
This is crazy, man. How do you deal with it?

DALTON
It's guys like you. My friends in low places keeping me high.

Dennis laughs and loads in the beer. He takes in the media.

DENNIS
I'll be back when shit dies down. Too much of a scene for me.

Dalton yanks up the beer and gives Dennis a playful salute which is quickly returned.

INT. WSAN - BOOTH

Gene records in a festive holiday sweater with his Producer dressed up as an Elf.

INT. CHURCH - DAY

A large mass is underway, as the congregation watches CHILDREN perform a terrible Christmas play about Jesus and the Three Wisemen.

GENE WERLEY (V.O.)
A very merry and unforgettable Christmas to you and yours from your family away from family here at Unforgettable, 1470 WSAN.

EXT. BETHLEHEM STEEL - DAY

A Picketer holds up a sign that says "All I Want For Christmas Is My Job Back."

EXT. BILLBOARD - DAY

"*We have been living here for '96' days*"

Fulmer, dressed in a full Santa Clause costume, scales the ladder to the top of the billboard with a giant bag slung over his shoulder. There are cameras and reporters both on the ground and atop the billboard. He gets to the top and starts handing out presents and posing for the cameras.

Krasja watches from the ground and motions for Fulmer to smile, like a stage-mom watching his daughter's pageant.

EXT. BETHLEHEM STEEL - NIGHT

The same picketer holds up the same sign but "Christmas" is crossed out and replaced with "New Year's."

EXT. BILLBOARD - NIGHT

Mike imitates Dick Clark pretending to interview Dalton as Ron counts down with both hands to the Small Crowd gathered below, Sue among them, impressed at the fun Ron seems to be having.

They hit zero and open a bottle of champagne, pouring it into plastic cups.

The sign reads: "*We have been living here for '102' days*"

INT. FULMER'S HOUSE - NIGHT

A modest New Year's Eve gathering at Fulmer's home. Harold holds court with a drink in hand. Krasja, more inebriated than the occasion calls for, tries to network with the few guests. Oplinger pulls Fulmer aside.

OPLINGER
I'm hearing it may be the worst blizzard in state history. The airports are already shut down and the power could go out at any second.

Harold seems to show some genuine concern for the first time.

FULMER
Did those boys sign liability waivers?

An inebriated Krasja throws his arm around Oplinger.

KRASJA
Standard for all contests.

Fulmer's concern immediately fades as he takes a swig of his scotch.

FULMER
Then there's nothing to worry about.

OPLINGER
Or they'll start a fire and burn themselves alive.

As Fulmer moves to refill his drink, he notices a woman listening in.

FULMER
Hello, Ms...

BETSY MORRIS
Betsy Morris. Wall Street Journal.

FULMER
Ah, your article has caused quite a stir Ms. Morris. We had reporters from Germany and Japan. I even did a radio interview with a station in New Zealand about the contest.

OPLINGER
I've always said promoting WSAN to New Zealand is a great use of our time.

BETSY
Mr. Fulmer, as a journalist my job is to present the facts as objectively as possible. But on a night like tonight with these temperatures and the impending storm it is very difficult, even through an objective lens, to view you as anything other than a heartless capitalist exploiting three desperate men for your personal gain and entertainment.

Oplinger stifles a smile.

FULMER
Ms. Morris, I reckon you don't know the first thing about me beyond what you see. If you had taken the time to interview me for your story, or even perform the most basic background research, you would know my father worked the mill. Our family had just enough to scrape by and never a penny more. The day I turned fourteen I got a job flipping burgers and mopping floors.
(MORE)

FULMER (CONT'D)
I wasn't an athlete or an artist or a scholar, I knew whatever I wanted from this world I was going to have to work for. So I worked. I was born here. I grew up here. I learned here and I achieved here. Allentown is my home. And the people of this town, people like me, work for what they want. I understand those boys more than anybody else because I've been in their shoes. Now, if you'll excuse me, I'm on the hunt for more donations. I am, after all, the largest benefactor. Imagine that. A heartless capitalist like me.

Fulmer storms off. Oplinger pats Betsy on the shoulder.

OPLINGER
Just be glad he didn't mention McDonald's.

INT. RON'S TENT - NIGHT

Ron tries to warm himself over his stove as he heats up some soup and talks on the phone. What little heat he can conserve does nothing as his breath chills in the air with every exhale.

RON
The other guys are kind of nice once you get to know them a little.

INT. KISTLER HOME - NIGHT

Mr. Kistler sits by the warm fire with a drink in his hand, talking to Ron on the phone.

MR. KISTLER
Easy there, son. You shouldn't be getting to know those boys. It's a competition. You just keep to yourself.

INT. RON'S TENT - NIGHT

RON
Yes, sir. I understand, sir. I promise. Bye.

He hangs up and turns on the radio.

RADIO (V.O.)
Authorities are warning people in affected areas to stay indoors as we are on track for record low temperatures and heavy snowfall.

Dalton unzips the tent and barges in, still wrapped up in a sleeping bag.

DALTON
Look man, in the army they taught us what to do in extreme weather situations. The unit needs to band together and conserve body heat.

RON
You're not sleeping here, Dalton.

DALTON
Fine. Freeze to death for all I care.

Dalton leaves the tent. Moments later Mike comes in.

MIKE
Hey bud. Nippy tonight. So... uhhh... I'm not sure how one man asks another man this, but--

RON
No, Mike, you can't sleep here.

MIKE
Yup, yup. Probably for the best.

Mike exits. Ron settles down, bundles up and takes a shallow exhale, painfully breathing in the freezing air.

MIKE (O.S.) (CONT'D)
Just don't get too handsy, Dalton.

DALTON (O.S.)
I need a tight hold to prevent heat from escaping our surface.

Ron is left alone in his tent, hearing the two of them settle in, getting colder and colder by the second.

INT. MIKE'S TENT - MORNING

Mike, Dalton and Ron, all wearing their Christmas beanies, are huddled together fast asleep. Ron, in the middle, opens his eyes first but is unable to move with Dalton and Mike nuzzled into him on each side.

The three men survived the night.

EXT. BILLBOARD - MORNING

The men slowly emerge from the tent, all still wrapped in sleeping bags and blankets. The highway and billboard are blanketed in two feet of snow. For the first time in almost five months there are no cars. There are no planes. There are no visitors. Just silence.

The boys take it all in.

MIKE
I forgot what quiet sounded like.

DALTON
Figures you would be the one to break it.

Mike chuckles.

RON
Had I known how noisy you would be I never would have climbed up.

MIKE
Well climb on down, fella. It's the only way this is going to end.

Ron thinks.

RON
Maybe not.

MIKE
What're you thinking?

Ron shakes his head.

RON
It doesn't seem right, after all we've been through. For only one of us to--

He trails off, his father's stern voice ringing through his head.

RON (CONT'D)
You know what? Nevermind.

DALTON
Know what I'm thinking? I'm thinking they have a lot full of those homes sitting there empty but won't hand them over because we're like show ponies. They know we aren't about to give up at this point so they can drag it out as long as they want.

MIKE
You know what it's like to marry the girl of your dreams, promise her the world and not even be able to afford rent? It's embarrassing. And I'm not easily embarrassed.

RON
This isn't a competition for me anymore. It's a way out. I feel like I'm trapped in a life I can't escape from. Like I'm still a kid under his parents' thumb.

MIKE
Fulmer can afford to buy us each a home with the loose change under his car seats. We shouldn't be fighting each other, we should be fighting him.

DALTON
"When the people have nothing more to eat, they will eat the rich."

MIKE
Who said that?

DALTON
I think it was on the poster of Dawn of the Dead.

Mike nods his approval.

MIKE
Smart film. I'm in.

DALTON
Ron?

Ron thinks about it.

RON
We signed a contract. We agreed to play by the rules. I can't just break them.

Dalton pulls out the rulebook from his tent.

DALTON
I didn't bring any books so I've read this thing backwards and forwards. Lots of rules about drug use, but nothing about putting the pressure on them to end the contest. And definitely nothing about how we can and can't use the media that keeps calling us.

He tosses the book to Ron.

RON
I'll think it over. Let's just enjoy the silence while we can.

He pauses and stares out at the empty expanse in front of them, blanketed in a sheen white.

RON (CONT'D)
Because something tells me it's about to get loud.

Mike and Dalton grin.

INT. OFFICE - DAY

The Chief of Police stands in front of Fulmer's desk.

CHIEF OF POLICE
Mornin' Hal. I was hoping to talk with you about that billboard business.

FULMER
Out with it.

CHIEF OF POLICE
We never expected it to last nearly this long. We figured a week or two tops. Now it's been pulling my guys away from important work. We're averaging two or three fender benders a week from rubberneckers and we've got partying down there almost every night. There's trash.
(MORE)

CHIEF OF POLICE (CONT'D)
Cigarette butts everywhere. And we keep getting calls about the portly gentleman washing himself in the nude.

FULMER
Is that all?

CHIEF OF POLICE
Well, it's a pretty big drain on resources.

FULMER
Has there been a crime committed?

CHIEF OF POLICE
I mean, technically, indecent exposure. I'm just saying that everybody comes away as a winner if the contest ends.

FULMER
Our permits are all in order. Our boys are behaving themselves. It sounds like things are taken care of on my end and the problems you're describing are an issue on your end.

INT. MIKE'S TENT - DAY

Mike sits with a bag of fan mail dropped off by the station, opening letter after letter addressed to Billboard Mike. Dalton pops his head in with a few envelopes.

DALTON
Got some Billboard Mikes in with mine.

MIKE
Here you go, good sir.

He hands Dalton a handful of envelopes addressed to Dalton and takes the Billboard Mike ones. As Dalton leaves Mike reads a letter in confusion.

MIKE (CONT'D)
Hey Ron...

EXT. BILLBOARD - DAY

Mike pops out of his tent where Ron reads a hunting magazine and Dalton goes through fan mail of his own.

RON
Told you, Mike. Not interested in any letters written to me.

MIKE
You may change your mind when you see this one.

He hands it over. Ron glances at it and his expression rankles.

RON
This can't be true.

He shows it to Dalton.

RON (CONT'D)
Did you get a letter from the government?

DALTON
I don't listen to the man. If they sent me a letter it went straight through these grates.

RON
It's a residency tax for fifteen dollars. The city has changed our primary residence to this billboard.

MIKE
They're charging us rent? I already have rent I can't pay.

EXT. BILLBOARD - DAY

A TALL REPORTER, hand picked by WSAN, speaks directly into the camera with the Billboard Boys behind him.

TALL REPORTER
What started as an amusing radio stunt by WSAN has garnered international media, but many local residents are starting to wonder if it's time to bring down the three men who have been living on a Route Twenty-Two billboard for one-hundred-and-sixty-three days. I'm here with Mike MacKay.

Mike grabs the microphone.

MIKE
That's Billboard Mike. Contact Linda MacKay for booking inquiries.

TALL REPORTER
It's been a rough few weeks. First a blizzard and now a tax bill?

MIKE
This is how they treat the have-nots. All around this great country are men like us stuck on their own metaphorical billboards.

He smirks, pleased with his use of the word 'metaphorical.'

INT. LOCAL BAR - DAY

Mike's group of regulars drink with the news on in the background.

DRUNK
Fuckin' eh.

EXT. BILLBOARD - DAY

The TALL REPORTER turns to Dalton.

TALL REPORTER
And how do you feel?

DALTON
They could give all three of us the homes we've clearly earned and end this circus right now.

TALL REPORTER
Finally, Ron, the other two clearly feel like they're being exploited by Harold Fulmer and the radio station. Do you?

Ron thinks for a moment, now's the moment of truth whether he backs up the guys or sticks to himself. There is a tense moment as Mike and Dalton wait for his response, knowing they need solidarity to survive.

RON
I don't know Harold Fulmer. Before this contest I didn't even know his name, but I've learned a little about him. I learned he likes to collect rare cars while most of us can barely afford the ones we've got. It's clear to me that Harold Fulmer has lost touch with guys like us.

QUICK SHOTS OF ALLENTOWN RESIDENTS WATCHING THE NEWS REPORT FROM HOME, INCLUDING MR. KISTLER, ACTUALLY LISTENING TO WHAT THE GUYS HAVE TO SAY.

RON
Guys who are up here by necessity because it's the only way we'll ever own a home. I'm beginning to think the only reason Fulmer hasn't put an end to this is because he likes watching the people beneath him suffer.

TALL REPORTER
For those wondering, we did pay a visit to Love Homes and there were plenty of units available. So even when a simple solution presents itself, it seems like these competitors have the deck firmly stacked against them.

EXT. BILLBOARD - DAY

The Tall Reporter packs up his van and is confronted by Krasja.

KRASJA
What the hell was that? You were supposed to do a puff piece and talk about the station.

TALL REPORTER
The story changed so we rolled with it.

KRASJA
That's not the story you pitched.

TALL REPORTER
No, it's a better one. Don't be pissed at me because your golden geese are laying rotten eggs.

Krasja looks up at the billboard, the silhouettes of Mike, Ron and Dalton towering over him through the sun.

Beneath them is the sign that now reads:

"*We have been living here for TOO DAMN LONG*"

EXT. BILLBOARD - NIGHT

Mike and Ron sit together wrapped in their winter coats and blankets, sharing a six-pack. Another generous donation from a passerby.

MIKE
You know what I never thought about? Where are we supposed to put these trailers? I don't even have an apartment, are they expecting me to drop it in a K-Mart parking lot or something?

RON
I've got a piece of land.

MIKE
Really?

RON
Yeah, we bought it before everything went bust. We were going to build there, but then...

MIKE
Yeah, but then. It's amazing how often "but then" screws us over.

RON
To me this is more than just a place to live. It's a sign that things might be heading in the right direction. I'm tired of living with all the cants that come with living with your parents.

MIKE
Like having a bunch of people over for a barbecue in the afternoon.

RON
The idea of being surrounded by that many people sounds pretty terrible to me. I was thinking more along the lines of getting married and starting a family.

Mike punches his shoulder.

MIKE
Different strokes for different folks. But that's what the American dream is. We're Americans, we can do anything we set our minds to.

Ron looks up at the sky and points to the moon.

RON
We even walked on the moon.

MIKE
Oh, don't tell me you believe that. Whole thing was fake.

RON
What do you mean?

MIKE
Stanley Kubrick shot it on one of Johnny Carson's soundstages in Burbank, California to stop the Russkies from setting up a military base.

RON
That doesn't make any sense.

MIKE
Watch the footage, man. When Neil Armstrong takes his first steps you can see the shadow of a boom mic.
(MORE)

MIKE (CONT'D)
And there weren't any stars in the sky, which is just lazy because they could have painted some on the roof of the studio.

RON
You sound crazy.

MIKE
Dalton knows what's up.
(calling)
Dalton! Hey, Dalton.

Dalton emerges from his tent.

DALTON
Huh?

MIKE
We're talking about how the moon landing never happened.

DALTON
Of course it didn't.

Mike tosses Dalton a beer and he joins the two of them.

MIKE
(to Ron)
See?

DALTON
Cause there is no moon.

RON
Here we go.

MIKE
What the hell do you mean there is no moon? We're looking right at the thing.

DALTON
Nah, that's a hologram.

Ron laughs as he takes another swig of his drink. He's actually begun to enjoy the company of these insane men.

MIKE
You're trying to tell me I'm looking at a hologram right now? Who would create a fake moon?

DALTON
The government, man.

RON
Guys, let's just enjoy the hologram.

The three men look up at the full moon. It's a quiet night.

DENNIS (O.S.)
Dalton, hey Dalton!

Dalton walks over to the edge of the billboard and sees Dennis Peters.

DALTON
Yo Steve. What brings you out?

DENNIS
It's Dennis. My guy's dry so I'm looking to get set up.

DALTON
I'm not dealing pot off a billboard, Steve.

DENNIS
Ah, c'mon. I've been hooking you up with beer since you've been up there. Just help me out. I know you're well equipped for the winter. I got a clean twenty for you.

DALTON
I don't want your money.

He looks over at Ron and Mike, both of whom are pretending not to listen. He thinks it over.

DALTON (CONT'D)
We just ran out of beer so buy me a six-pack and we'll be square.

Dalton reaches into his tent and pulls out a joint. He places it in a small bucket and sends it down to Dennis.

Dennis pulls out the joint and quietly slips a twenty in the bucket. Dalton pulls it up and sees the money.

DALTON (CONT'D)
The hell's this? I said I don't want your money.

He looks over the edge, but Dennis is gone.

INT. MACKAY APARTMENT - MORNING

The phone rings. Linda answers.

LINDA
Hello?

INT. MIKE'S TENT - INTERCUT

MIKE
Did you catch the news last night?

LINDA
Of course. Residency tax?

MIKE
Don't worry, we're not paying it.

LINDA
We couldn't if we wanted to. We have nine dollars in our checking account.

MIKE
Well I have something that will cheer you up. Come down here.

LINDA
Why?

MIKE
Because I just called the station and told them I'm coming down.

EXT. BILLBOARD - MORNING

Mike emerges from his tent. He looks out at the landscape and inhales, a slight smile forming on his face.

INT. WSAN STUDIO - DAY

Gene broadcasts.

GENE WERLEY
Well, the day has finally come folks.

He continues to broadcast over images of cars and news trucks driving down the highway and setting up shop at the billboard. One of Harold's many luxury cars not far behind.

GENE WERLEY (O.S.) (CONT'D)
Mike MacKay, who has gained quite the following as Billboard Mike, called the station and declared his intention to climb down from the billboard this afternoon.

EXT. BILLBOARD - DAY

Harold steps out of his car and is greeted by Krasja who walks him through the media to the base of the billboard. Ron stands stoically, as if he doesn't notice the commotion. He waves to Sue.

FULMER
This is quite the turn out.

KRASJA
And the best case scenario, he comes down healthy of his own volition and once one domino falls...

GENE WERLEY (V.O.)
Ron Kistler and Dalton Young will be one step closer to home ownership.

Linda, dressed to the nines, scurries down the hill and finds a spot near the bottom of Mike's side of the billboard.

The crowd waits silently for Mike to emerge from his tent, straining to see up on the billboard. Fulmer glances at his watch and steps forward.

FULMER
Okay, son, come on down. The cameras are ready and rolling.

There are some chuckles but no Mike, though his tent flap is wide open. Fulmer turns and nods to Krasja, who moves towards the board and begins to ascend the ladder. Once at the top rung, Krasja looks around.

KRASJA
I don't see him.

There's a murmur among the crowd. Linda looks confused and slightly concerned.

FULMER
Well go look inside the tent!

Krasja pokes his head in the tent.

REPORTER
I can't believe it's April and we're still here covering these guys.

Fulmer overhears the comment. A thought dawns on him.

KRASJA
Hal, he's really not here.

FULMER
There's not many places he can be. Get inside the tent and really look around.

Krasja exhales and climbs into the tent in his suit.

INT. MIKE'S TENT - DAY

Krasja kneels down by the cot, which has several food and clothing items stuffed beneath it, and begins moving them out of the way. As he pulls away a crumpled flannel shirt he sees Mike's grinning face from underneath the cot.

MIKE
Hiya, Matty.

Krasja SCREAMS like a child. The crowd, having heard nothing but Krasja's SCREAM, waits with baited breath until Mike emerges from his tent and holds up his hands in triumph.

MIKE (CONT'D)
April Fools!

Linda's face drops with anguish. She turns and runs for her car. As she reaches her car she hears a voice.

SUE
Linda, wait!

Linda turns. Her eyes are welled with tears.

SUE (CONT'D)
You didn't deserve that.

Linda nods a silent 'thank you.'

Fulmer fumes on his way back to his car where Oplinger waits for him.

OPLINGER
The housing inspector called. They're considering evicting your boys because the billboard doesn't have plumbing or smoke alarms.

FULMER
Not now, Gordon.

OPLINGER
You need to end this.

Fulmer stops walking.

FULMER
I want you gone until the contest is over. Lancaster or home, I don't care.

OPLINGER
You're sending away the only voice of reason you have left.

FULMER
And yet the ringing in my ears persists.

Oplinger holds Fulmer's gaze, then turns and walks.

EXT. BILLBOARD - LATER

All is quiet. The base of the billboard, littered with cans and bottles, becomes slowly illuminated by approaching headlights. A ladder quietly tips against Dalton's end of the billboard.

INT. DALTON'S TENT - NIGHT

Dalton wakes to the sound of his tent being unzipped. He springs from his cot and re-zips the tent.

DALTON
Let me put some pants on first.

The tent flap immediately unzips and a flashlight points directly into Dalton's eyes. He squints, disoriented.

OFFICER
Mr. Dalton Young?

EXT. BILLBOARD - NIGHT

Mike and Ron bundle up as they emerge from their tents and see two officers flanking Dalton as another searches his tent.

RON
What's going on?

MIKE
Hey, you can't just search his property.

OFFICER
It's city property. We received an anonymous tip that Mr. Young is in possession of illegal narcotics and has been dealing marijuana from the billboard.

DALTON
That's ridiculous and slanderous.

Another Officer emerges from the tent with some joints and nunchucks.

DALTON (CONT'D)
And medicinal. It's for my PTSD.

The Officers take Dalton down the ladder.

RON
Dalton, we'll figure this out.

DALTON
Watch your back, Ron.

MIKE
Whoa, you don't think I did this.

DALTON
An 'anonymous tip?' One less obstacle on your drive to fame.

Ron and Mike watch helplessly as Dalton is led into a squad car and driven away.

INT. ALLENTOWN POLICE STATION - DAY

Dalton emerges from a holding cell and hugs his Mother. As they walk through the halls he spots Dennis Peters in a police uniform. They make eye contact.

Dalton's face hardens as he gives Dennis a military salute. Dennis turns away, ashamed.

INT. LAW OFFICES - DAY

RICHARD MAKOUL, a stocky man with dark, curly hair and dark eyes, sits at his desk in a law office that can only be described as "The best Dalton can afford."

RICHARD MAKOUL
This is a textbook case of entrapment. If not for the actions of the police officer you never would have made a sale. In fact, you never intended to make a sale. He claimed to be a fellow soldier to prey on your sense of loyalty and went there that night to encourage a sale, I would go so far as to say entice a sale. Does that sound accurate?

Dalton nods stoically.

RICHARD MAKOUL (CONT'D)
Okay, good. We're on the same page with our defense. Now I can't get you re-instated in the competition, that's between you and WSAN, I'm just trying to keep you out of prison.

Dalton nods stoically.

RICHARD MAKOUL (CONT'D)
The thing we need to be worried about is eye witness testimony. They're moving fast on the trial and I got word they intend to subpoena Mike and Ron. Did those two ever see you do anything illegal.

Dalton takes off his aviators and looks up at Richard.

EXT. BILLBOARD - DAY

A rain soaked day. A line of reporters face the billboard. Fulmer pulls up to the base of the billboard in his Jaguar. He steps out and locks eyes with the Chief of Police, seeming to double in size as the Chief averts his gaze.

Fulmer turns to the media.

FULMER
To show that I have my full support behind Mike and Ron in this terribly inappropriate situation, I'm going to personally drive them to the courthouse for their testimonies.

Mike and Ron stand atop the only home they've known for six months. They look at each other and begin descending their ladders. Their feet touch at the same time and they share a look as they let their feet sink into the soggy ground. Mike bends down and puts his hand in the mud.

MIKE
Haven't felt that in a while.
(to the media)
It's like Allentown's walk of fame.

He gives Fulmer a big handshake. Fulmer shakes off the dirt in disgust.

MIKE (CONT'D)
Good to see you, Harry. Hope there's no hard feelings from all those barbs we've been giving ya in the media.

FULMER
Of course not, boys. It's honorable to see you take up arms.

He smiles as his grip tightens on Mike's hand.

FULMER (CONT'D)
Just make sure when you pick a fight it's one you're willing to lose.

INT. RON'S HOTEL ROOM - DAY

Ron stands in the bathroom staring at his reflection in the mirror, marveling at his shag of hair and blonde beard.

INT. KISTLER HOME - DAY

Ron's father answers a RINGING phone.

MR. KISTLER
Hello.

INT. RON'S HOTEL ROOM - DAY

Ron is still a bit wet from the shower with a towel draped over his bare shoulders. He's freshly shaven and cleaned up, looking like the Ron from before the contest. He paces with the phone in his hand.

RON
Hey dad.

INTERCUT

MR. KISTLER
Hello Ronald. Are you at the courthouse?

RON
Headed there soon. I could use some advice.

MR. KISTLER
Then it's good you called me.

RON
You always told me to be a man of character. Don't lie and be loyal. If one of those two is unavoidable, which is worse?

MR. KISTLER
You tell the truth, son.

RON
Even if it sends Dalton to prison.

MR. KISTLER
That's not for you to decide. That decision will be made by the court based on the law.

RON
What if he was set up?

MR. KISTLER
I know this is a difficult situation, but I also know deep down, when the moment arrives, you'll do what you know is right.

Ron lets his father's words sink in.

RON
Thanks, dad.

INT. COURTROOM - DAY

Mike and Ron are led into the sparse courtroom. There is no jury, no cheering audience. Its quite barren with a few media members taking notes, a prosecutor, Dalton and Richard Makoul sitting in front of JUDGE MILLS, a large, stern man with an authoritative demeanor. In the gallery, Dennis Peters sits in a full police uniform. Dalton clocks him but says nothing.

COURTROOM DEPUTY CLERK
Mr. MacKay, Mr. Kistler, please raise your right hands.

Mike and Ron oblige.

COURTROOM DEPUTY CLERK (CONT'D)
Do you both swear to tell the truth, the whole truth and nothing but the truth so help you God?

MIKE
I do.

Ron nods.

COURTROOM DEPUTY CLERK
Verbally please, Mr. Kistler.

RON
I do.

JUDGE MILLS
We'll do this one at a time. Mr. MacKay, please take a seat.

Ron and Mike sit side by side in the same witness stand.

JUDGE MILLS (CONT'D)
I know this is an inconvenience, so I will ask you each one question and then allow you to be on your way. Have you ever seen Mr. Young provide marijuana to anybody, compensated or otherwise. Mr. MacKay?

MIKE
Dalton is an upstanding citizen, a veteran of our armed forces. A bonafide war hero and he deserves to be treated with respect. He is the last person in the world who would involve himself in illegal activities.
(MORE)

MIKE (CONT'D)
In fact, he would preach the dangers of marijuana to all who passed by. "Repent" he would scream from the edge of the billboard. "Repent now and save your soul for Jesus."

JUDGE MILLS
Thats enough, Mr. MacKay. Mr. Kistler?

Ron slowly leans into the mic. He looks at Dalton and the officers sitting behind him, including Dennis Peters in his full police uniform.

RON
No sir, I have not.

INT. HOTEL ROOM - DAY

Linda sits on the edge of the bed waiting. Mike enters from the bathroom, freshly showered, and stops when he sees her face.

MIKE
Hey. How'd you get here?

LINDA
I need you to come home, Mike.

MIKE
We talked about this. Just a little bit lon--

LINDA
I'm not asking. I sat in that apartment alone for six months. I watched you humiliate me on national television. I pick up your shifts and bring you food and cheer you on and you don't even ask if I'm okay. So I'm telling you. Come home or I won't be there when you do.

Mike starts to speak but catches himself. He can see she means it.

INT. FULMER'S CAR - DAY

Fulmer drives Mike and Ron back to the billboard, peering through the windshield for the media that didn't bother to come cover their return.

FULMER
What you guys did back there took balls.

MIKE
I'm surprised you're not more upset. Thought you hauled Dalton down to try and tear us apart.

FULMER
If I wanted to end the competition there are simpler ways to do it that don't reflect negatively on the station. Sadly, I don't seem to have the same level of loyalty in my circle that Dalton does.

The men exit the car. Ron looks back.

RON
One question, sir.

FULMER
Shoot, son.

RON
What do you really want out of this?

FULMER
I can't say I understand.

RON
The contest. I mean, it's gone on so long that it can't be for ratings or ad dollars anymore. And buying us out wouldn't put a dent in your pocket, so I can't figure out why you let it drag on.

MIKE
I think I know.

FULMER
Enlighten us.

MIKE
You're like me. It's the reason you drove us back here. Six months ago nobody in Allentown knew either of our names, but now every couple weeks or so we're both back on the front page of newspapers across the country. It's like a drug, isn't it? The only difference is that I'll be Billboard Mike for the rest of my life. I can go off and turn that into my career. But you have businesses to run and corporate responsibilities, so when the contest ends you don't get to be this larger-than-life radio station owner. When this ends you have to go back to being Harold Fulmer The Third.

Fulmer tips his hat to Mike.

FULMER
Evening, boys.

EXT. BILLBOARD - DAY

Mike and Ron hoist up the ladder at the abandoned board and climb back up and come face-to-face with Betsy lounging in one of their chairs.

BETSY
The billboard scene has changed. They'll let anybody up here nowadays.

RON
Ms. Morris?

MIKE
Betsy, my gal! Haven't seen you in a minute. You here for another interview. A Billboard Mike exclusive, maybe?

BETSY
Maybe when this whole thing is over I can do a big profile, but for now I'm being sent to a small town in Ohio whose entire Main Street is boarded up. I just wanted to say goodbye and let you know I'm rooting for you.

Ron still can't believe the situation he's in. He's the last person he would have expected to be on the front line of a class war representing the blue-collar worker.

RON
You sure started something here.

BETSY
I may have started it, but it's up to you to finish it.

EXT. BILLBOARD - DUSK

As Mike and Ron sit together they hear the unmistakable sound of a ladder hitting the edge of the billboard.

Moments later a bag from Andre’s Cheesesteaks flies over the edge.

DALTON
Told you I would treat you guys when I got down.

Mike tosses Dalton a beer.

MIKE
How you feeling?

DALTON
I'm free as a bird and high as a... slightly less free bird.

He drinks it in.

DALTON (CONT’D)
I missed this dump. What happened while I was gone?

MIKE
Linda told me she's leaving if I don't come home soon so there's that.

RON
And Sue's parents aren't exactly thrilled about their daughter's boyfriend's primary residence be a billboard.

DALTON
Just wanted to thank you guys for what you did today. May have made all the difference.

RON
So the sentencing went well?

DALTON
Hell no. Guilty on all charges. But I was given probation. I was already getting paranoid about that Dennis guy. Not a surprise he showed up right as we started pushing back at the station.

The men ponder this.

DALTON (CONT'D)
I got you guys something else.

He pulls out the wet and filthy copy of Penthouse with Morgan Fairchild's seductive look transformed into a shell of its former self.

RON
You know what, Dalton? I think you do need that more than us.

They LAUGH and CLINK bottles. Enjoying the sunset together.

INT. FULMER'S HOUSE - NIGHT

Fulmer shares a scotch with Krasja.

FULMER
That sure was an interesting day.

KRASJA
It's about to get more interesting. Donahue's people called again.

FULMER
What's his ask?

KRASJA
You, MacKay and Kistler in studio Wednesday. They don't understand why we're stonewalling them but let the boys come down for court.

FULMER
I guess there's no use avoiding it forever. Brown or white?

KRASJA
Sorry?

FULMER
My suit. Obviously the boys won't be at the show but there's no reason I can't sit for an interview.

KRASJA
Hal, you can't go on this show.

FULMER
We're getting hammered in the media. The boys have turned on us. I need a forum to tell my side of the story and Donahue has the biggest talk show in America. It's the perfect opportunity to shift the focus back.

KRASJA
I totally agree that we should go and shift the narrative. I don't think it should be you.

FULMER
Why not?

KRASJA
You thrive on a warm audience. The "ah shucks" schtick isn't going to fool Donahue. He'll be on the attack from the moment you arrive and will do everything in his power to break you. You either snap and look exactly how they're portraying you or you play up the humble beginnings persona and look naive. There's too much for you to lose here.

FULMER
Well what exactly do you recommend?

INT. TELEVISION STUDIO - BACKSTAGE - DAY

Krasja, dressed in a dark suit, stands nervously behind a curtain. Phil Donahue walks briskly past him.

DONAHUE
The segment goes by really quick. If you have something you need to say, say it.

Donahue grabs Krasja by the shoulders, positions him on a mark, and slips through the curtain.

KRASJA
It was nice to meet you too.

Krasja sees a small monitor playing a quick recap video of the Billboard Boys story for the audience.

KRASJA (CONT'D)
So cool.

INT. THE DONAHUE SHOW - STUDIO - DAY

Phil Donahue speaks directly into the camera.

PHIL DONAHUE
We're now joined in studio by Matthew Krasja, one of the masterminds behind the billboard sitter contest.

INT. FULMER'S HOUSE - DAY

With a scotch in one hand and a cigar in the other, Fulmer puts his cowboy boots up and leans back in his BarcaLounger with Donahue on the television in front of him.

INT. THE DONAHUE SHOW - STUDIO - DAY

KRASJA
Thank you for having me, Phil.

PHIL DONAHUE
So tell me how this all came about.

KRASJA
We were looking for ways to promote WSAN as the new home of top-forty hits in Allentown and were reminded of the flagpole sitters.

PHIL DONAHUE
Flagpole sitters were citizens who lost everything in the Great Depression and would sit atop flagpoles for a chance to win a prize, correct?

KRASJA
Well that's a broad generalization, but the idea is similar, sure. The point I'm trying to make is that current marketing strategies can evolve out of the great techniques of the past. I think what we're doing is effective while helping the local community.

PHIL DONAHUE
I admire you drawing on the lessons of the past, but does this not feel like kicking somebody when they're down?

KRASJA
These men chose to enter the contest because they realized the opportunity of a lifetime was being presented to them.

PHIL DONAHUE
The very fact that they can spend almost a year on a billboard must be a reflection of their economic situation.

KRASJA
But that's not our fault. All we can do is try to help out whenever possible and this is a great first step.

PHIL DONAHUE
But what's the second step? The promotion's been a monumental success, so why not end it and call it a day?

KRASJA
I couldn't agree more and I think if the boys wanted us to end the contest we would gladly do so. But as they've said, in no uncertain terms, they don't want a handout. They want to compete.

DONAHUE
Why don’t we ask them?

He motions to a monitor with a live-feed of Mike and Ron, leaning over the edge of the billboard.

DONAHUE (CONT'D)
Welcome gentlemen, how are we doing today?

MIKE
Really cold, Phil. Too bad they didn't have a station in California to promote.

Donahue cracks a smile as Krasja shuffles uncomfortably in his seat.

DONAHUE
I'm here with Matthew Krasja, who was just telling me they would end the competition but neither of you want a handout.

There is a bit of silence as the time delay hits them.

RON
I haven't had a stable trucking job since the plants moved out of state two years ago. I work shifts as a painter and odds jobs when I can get them and I spend the mornings waiting in line outside of whatever mill is still open, hoping to be one of the three people to get work that day. We're giving up our lives for this. Every second up here is a second I don't get to spend with my girl. You think we're too prideful to take a handout? People of Allentown can't afford to have pride. Pride left town with the rest of the jobs.

MIKE
You say we don't want a handout. I say give me everything you got.

PHIL DONAHUE
It sure doesn't sound like they're opposed to ending the contest in a tie.

KRASJA
Look, the competition has rules and we don't want to break the integrity of that.

PHIL DONAHUE
It doesn't sound like you have much integrity to break.

Krasja becomes flustered.

MIKE
Let's just be real here and say it like it is. Ron was right when he said we're giving up our lives. We're dying up here. Mr. Krasja and Harold G. Fulmer the Third are just exploiting us to promote their radio station.

PHIL DONAHUE
That's an explosive accusation. How do you respond?

KRASJA
That's obviously ridiculous, Phil. We're not exploiting them and.. It's... Look, they were talking about the economy in Allentown. Those homes are expensive and we were lucky to have Love Homes donate one.

PHIL DONAHUE
WSAN's parent company is HGF Group, an eighty million dollar business empire owned by Harold Fulmer, correct? He's a multi-millionaire who collects classic cars and has spent this last year playing up his business successes in the press.

INT. FULMER'S HOUSE - DAY

Fulmer pours himself another drink.

FULMER
God-damned right I do.

INT. THE DONAHUE SHOW - STUDIO - DAY

KRASJA
This is about WSAN and not Mr. Fulmer.

PHIL DONAHUE
It sounds like you're punishing the average working-class American for daring to stand up to the corporate entity that owns them.

KRASJA
We're not punishing them.

PHIL DONAHUE
At this point you're either punishing them or exploiting them.

Krasja finally breaks.

KRASJA
Absolutely we're exploiting them.

The crowd doesn't need any prompting this time to GASP with shock.

Krasja doesn't back down. He turns and looks directly into one of the broadcast cameras.

KRASJA (CONT'D)
People in Allentown have problems, but it wasn't WSAN that abandoned them, we weren't the ones who drove manufacturing out of the country. If you want to blame us go ahead, every story needs a villain, right? I guess WSAN and Fulmer fit that bill real nice. But when the cameras turn off and the media circus moves onto its next story, the people in Allentown aren't going to be better off.

Krasja catches his breath and changes his tone.

AS KRASJA SPEAKS WE SEE QUICK FLASHES OF PEOPLE ALL AROUND ALLENTOWN WATCHING THE SHOW. THE CREW IN WSAN. THE DRUNKS AT THE BAR. THE CAFETERIA WAITING ROOM. THE RICH. THE POOR. ALL OF ALLENTOWN IS GLUED TO THE SCREEN.

KRASJA
You're part of this too. I mean, how much did this segment cost? You flew me out here and put me up in a fancy hotel, what did you pay to send your camera crew and producers down to Allentown to broadcast this?
(MORE)

KRASJA (CONT'D)
If they flip the camera around, how many production trucks are we going to see? You could easily buy those guys a home yourself, but you chose to spend that money on a segment for ratings. How is that not the same thing you're accusing us of? How are you not part of the problem? How is everyone who reports on this, and tunes in to watch, not just as culpable? So yeah, you can say we exploited them. But every one of you who watched did the same damn thing.

Krasja looks out into the audience.

KRASJA (CONT'D)
If there's a crime here then we're all complicit.

Donahue smirks, always knowing how to manipulate somebody into giving him the outburst he wants.

PHIL DONAHUE
When we come back the boys will give us some tips on how to survive if you lose your home and find yourself sleeping outside. So stay tuned, we'll be right back with more from Allentown.

IN-STUDIO PRODUCER (O.S.)
Clear.

Krasja exhales and sinks into his chair.

PHIL DONAHUE
Well done, son. None of it will survive the edit but I'm glad you managed to get it off your chest.

INT. FULMER'S MANSION - DAY

A wide shot reveals a disheveled Krasja sitting next to Fulmer. The show was taped, not live. This is the first time Krasja has dressed casually and isn't in a suit. Fulmer slowly turns to him.

FULMER
And you thought Donahue would break me?

KRASJA
It's different in person. There are so many people there and the lights are so hot and there are so many people there.

FULMER
"Absolutely we're exploiting them?"

KRASJA
I had a whole speech about how the media that reports on these situations exploits their subjects just as much as they accuse others of doing, but he cut all of it.

Fulmer pours himself and Krasja another drink. He stands and walks over to the window, staring out deep in thought.

EXT. BILLBOARD - NIGHT

Ron and Mike lean against the rail of the billboard. Not another soul is around as the sun sets over the mountains.

"*We have been living here for '260' Days*"

MIKE
How long will you stay up here really? No bullshit.

RON
As long as it takes.

Ron smiles at Mike and gives him a hearty pat on the back.

MIKE
Same answer every time. Dalton's in jail and we're stuck on a billboard. Where did life go so wrong that I'm jealous of Dalton? At least he's got four walls and a roof. Love Homes. You'll Love To Live With Us.

Mike shakes his head.

RON
I already love where I live.

Mike looks at Ron's meticulously maintained tent then glances at his lopsided and weathered one. Compared to Ron's, Mike's looks like it belongs under an overpass.

MIKE
It is a pretty sweet tent.

RON
Not here. Home home.

MIKE
You still live with your parents. What's to love?

RON
Being with Sue. Doesn't matter where we are.

MIKE
Don't you want more? I always want more.

RON
You can want more and still be happy with what you've got.

Mike thinks over Ron's words.

MIKE
You sound like Linda. She says I look for the easy way out, the quick fix. Maybe she's right. Maybe that's all this is. An easy way out. Why earn a house when you can win one.

RON
You lived on this billboard for two-hundred-and-sixty days. Bad sleep. Bad food. Planes flying overhead. Tin cans being thrown at us. Dalton's psychic attacks. Not to mention a blizzard. If you were looking for an easy way out you did a pretty shit job.

Mike non-verbally acknowledges Ron's point.

RON (CONT'D)
My dad told me once that every man should build a home and fill it with people he loves. Sometimes it doesn't work out. But all we can do is move forward. Wake up every day and keep trying. Linda and Sue deserve that much, I think.

EXT. BILLBOARD - MORNING

Ron emerges from his tent with two dirty mugs of coffee.

RON
Hey, Mike. Got your usual.

No answer.

RON (CONT'D)
Mike.

Still nothing. Ron moves to open Mike's tent but notices a note pinned to it.

RON (CONT'D)
(reading)
I spent almost a year of my life sleeping next to you. I'm going to go spend the rest of it sleeping next to her. Enjoy the home, buddy. You earned it. - Billboard Mike. PS I once told a reporter you were a mute hillbilly. Apologies.

Ron's mouth hangs open. He looks around to celebrate but he is the sole survivor. There isn't a single person to hear him HOWL at the top of his lungs. His SCREAMS of joy are interrupted by his phone ringing.

INT. RON'S TENT - MORNING

Ron grabs it.

RON
Hello?

INT. WSAN STUDIO - DAY

Gene Werley holds the phone.

GENE WERLEY
Well congratulations, Ron. It's Early Werley.

INTERCUT RON / GENE

RON
We on the air?

GENE WERLEY
Nope, giving you the good news live on the air would make way too much sense for this ass-backwards contest.

RON
So you already heard. News travels fast in Allentown.

GENE WERLEY
Of course I heard. I'm the one telling you.

RON
I'm sorry?

GENE WERLEY
Fulmer caved and decided to make you both winners. You'll each be getting a home and however many additional prizes Fulmer thinks will win back the bad publicity from Donahue. We're going to announce it on air and get the media out there to bring you down around noon.

RON
What time is it now?

GENE WERLEY
Almost nine. And can you let Mike know. He won't answer his phone.

INT. MIKE'S TENT - DAY

All of Mike's important possessions are gone, yet the tent still looks like it's home to a family of raccoons. Ron checks under the cot. No April Fool's joke this time. Mike is really gone. Ron settles on the floor.

RON
Mike, you idiot. You stupid, selfless idiot. What the hell have you done?

His eyes lock on to Mike's book Cooking Varmints and Other Little Critters. On the back is Mike's author headshot taking up the full page and right beneath that is his contact information. Including his home address.

Ron can't decide what to do. If he just sits still for the next few hours then everything he wants will be his. There's one person he always promised to call for advice when he's stuck in a tight place. He picks up the phone... but lets it dangle in his hands.

He hangs up.

EXT. BILLBOARD - DAY

Ron's boots SLAM into the mud beneath the billboard. He wears a pair of Dalton's Aviator shades and one of Mike's trucker hats. He looks around, shoves the book in his coat pocket and runs to the nearby woods.

INT. STATION - OFFICE - DAY

Fulmer fixes his tie. Janice walks in and hands him a styrofoam cup of coffee.

JANICE
What did you decide?

FULMER
A house for each guy, plus a car and two vacations for each of them. I feel like a loser.

JANICE
Well, you can't have a contest without one.

INT. WSAN RADIO STATION - MORNING

Krasja passes Werley in the hall.

KRASJA
You tell them?

GENE WERLEY
I told Ron the deal and had him inform Mike. For whatever reason Mike wouldn't answer his phone.

Gene keeps moving. Krasja stops.

KRASJA
Mike didn't answer?

He thinks, then turns with purpose.

INT. MACKAY APARTMENT - DAY

Linda opens the door with a bag of groceries and almost drops them when she sees Mike sitting at the kitchen table.

MIKE
Surprise.

She puts the bag on the counter and takes a seat across from him.

LINDA
I've spent a lot of time thinking about what I would say when I saw you again. I thought about it while I was at work doing both of our jobs. I thought about it when I was bringing you food and watching you flirt with college girls. When I was trying to fall asleep alone or when I was trying to convince my friends and parents that this was all in our best interest. Because that's what you kept telling me. That this was all for us. Our head start. Our lottery ticket. But at some point it changed from being about us to being about you. The microphones, the cameras, those were your prize. Not the home. I tried my best to be supportive, I really did. But then you absolutely humiliated me with that stunt of yours. You could have told me. But instead there was footage of me crying on the news every night for a week. And now you walk in here after all this time and want me to what? Jump into your arms because you won a home? I married a loving, caring man who had nothing and I would give anything to have him back.

MIKE
Then I've got some good news for you.

Linda looks confused.

MIKE (CONT'D)
I didn't win the home. I climbed down this morning and walked here to apologize to you and to promise you that you won't go another night without me. Ever again. No matter where home is.

Linda's face softens.

LINDA
If this is another prank, so help me God, Michael.

Mike holds up his hand with the boy scout salute.

MIKE
Scout's honor. Ron's probably being shown around his home as we speak.

There is a FRANTIC BANG on the window. Mike and Linda walk over to see the DISHEVELED RON balancing in the tree outside the window BANGING INTENSELY.

MIKE (CONT'D)
Wow, gone one year and the whole neighborhood changes.

RON
It's me. Let me in!

MIKE
Ron?

He opens up the window and, with some struggle, manages to get Ron inside where he collapses in a heap, but quickly jumps back to his feet and speaks between deep wheezes.

RON
You need to come back!

MIKE
Aw bud, I'm sure it's not that bad without me.

RON
You don't understand. They ended the contest.

MIKE
Well, yeah. That's how the process works.

Ron grabs Mike by the collar.

RON
Just listen to me you big, dumb dummy.

MIKE
Well that seems unnaturally aggressive.

RON
Please, for once in your life stop talking and listen.

Mike remains silent. Ron takes a DEEP BREATH.

RON (CONT'D)
They don't know you left. Fulmer caved and he's ending the contest at noon and making us both winners and giving us each a home and maybe other stuff I don't know but I know why you did what you did and I think it's great even though it's very out of character for you in the best possible way but you deserve this thing as much as I do so we need to get back to the billboard right now or neither of us will get anything!

Even though Ron's still holding Mike's collar, Mike is the one holding Ron up.

MIKE
I would love to, Ron, but I made my wife a promise and I int--

LINDA
Are you fucking kidding me? Go! Go right now!

MIKE
Yes, ma'am.

Mike sprints to the exit as Ron runs back to the window. Mike runs back in, grabs Ron and they run together back to the front door.

EXT. HIGHWAY - DAY

Krasja drives down the highway singing along to Allentown, totally oblivious to the two figures SPRINTING through the field parallel to him outside his window.

EXT. FIELD - DAY

Mike and Ron continue to run toward the billboard. Mike stops and kneels over, speaking breathlessly and desperately.

MIKE
Ronny, I got a side sticker. I might need a quick breather. My thighs are rubbing together. I can feel the rash forming. These aren't appropriate running clothes.

RON
I thought you were a natural athlete and vigorous outdoorsman.

MIKE
Give me a break, man. I spent the last year living on a billboard.

EXT. BILLBOARD - DAY

Ron and Mike sneak carefully up to the front of the billboard. The coast seems clear. Ron quickly hops on the ladder and starts climbing with Mike close behind. They reach the top, climb onto the platform and...

KRASJA
Good morning, gentlemen.

Krasja waits for them.

KRASJA (CONT'D)
Seems like we have a bit of a problem here.

Mike and Ron are stunned. Neither knows how to react.

KRASJA (CONT'D)
When I heard you didn't answer your phone this morning I had this little tingle. Just a sense, you know? Billboard Mike not answering his phone? It just didn't sit right. So I came out here and would you believe it - the billboard was empty. I walked around, checked each tent, called out your names just to be sure and... not a thing.

A fleet of cars begins to arrive outside the billboard. Krasja looks off at the spectacle unfolding below them. The climax of their story.

KRASJA (CONT'D)
So now I have to decide how to play this. I could save Fulmer's money and send you two packing with nothing but the knowledge that you wasted a year of your lives. The fall from grace when Honest Ron and Billboard Mike are revealed as cheats.

MIKE
(whispering to Ron)
'Honest Ron'?

He motions out over Allentown and the stream of vehicles coming down the highway towards them.

KRASJA
Those people out there, they became so invested in you because they really needed something to believe in. Good vs. Evil, the struggle of man against the world. Stories are what make people pick up their phones and call into the morning radio show. And it was one hell of a story.

Ron and Mike glance at each other.

KRASJA (CONT'D)
But a story is only as good as its ending and you guys winning is the one our audience needs. So... congrats.

He moves to the railing.

RON
That's it? After everything?

KRASJA
Yeah. That's it. I mean, if you really feel the need to thank me consider saying something nice about the station for a change once you hit the ground. Maybe it'll help them not make my job a complete living hell after that Donahue fiasco.

MIKE
You can always quit.

KRASJA
In this economy? You really are funny, Billboard Mike.

Krasja smiles and begins to walk down the ladder.

MIKE
We really thought you hated us.

Krasja looks back at them from the ladder.

KRASJA
I'm not a monster, guys. I'm just in marketing.

Krasja climbs down past the sign:

"*We have been living here for '261' Days*"

EXT. BILLBOARD - DAY

The sun shines brightly on the Media that sets up in the cloverleaf. Sue and Linda stand at the base, eagerly.

Fulmer orchestrates every step, pointing out where the cameras should be set up and making sure the BRASS BAND is ready to play. He's gone out of his way to make this a spectacle. He raises his hand to silence the crowd and lifts a megaphone to his mouth.

FULMER
Okay, gentleman. Your castles await. Come on down!

Mike and Ron step onto their ladders and make their way down to the ground.

Nearing the bottom, Mike playfully starts running back up the rungs to the delight of the gathered onlookers. Ron laughs and waits for Mike to come back down. They both stand one step from the ground with Linda and Sue waiting just out of reach.

FULMER (CONT'D)
On the count of three... One... Two... Three!

Mike and Ron hop onto the ground to CHEERS. Mike picks up Linda and kisses her passionately and triumphantly as flash bulbs pop. Ron hugs Sue tightly, not needing to make a show of it but needing to feel her against him.

FULMER (CONT'D)
To you two gentlemen I say, congratulations.

He POPS open the cork on a bottle of champagne and begins pouring as the band PLAYS and the crowd ERUPTS. Ron comes face to face with Fulmer who reaches out his hand as the camera moves in and frames the two men together mid-handshake.

FULMER (CONT'D)
You've got fight in you. I can make use of that.

RON
Are you offering me a job?

FULMER
Not many people can say they took me on and came out on top. I prefer to keep those people by my side.

He pats Ron on the back and moves to the media where he wraps an arm around Mike to budge into his interview. There is a jostling between the two as they each try to pull focus of the reporters.

SUE
Let's go home.

Ron doesn't even look back as he hops into Sue's truck and they drive away from the billboard and the media circus surrounding it.

INT. BED - DAY

Close-up on Ron as he rests, his eyes closed and a relaxed smile on his face. Living his nice, quiet life.

SUE
Ron?

Sue nudges Ron from where he lays on their bed.

RON
I'm never taking this for granted again.

SUE
Your guests are here.

Ron gets out of bed and walks through the home, running his fingers along the walls - his walls.

EXT. RON'S HOME - DAY

Ron exits his new Love Homes luxury prefab mobile living space on what used to be an empty lot that housed only possibilities.

Outside is what used to sound like Ron's worst nightmare: a noisy barbecue with friends and family. Ron waves as Mike and Linda pull up the driveway in their new Pontiac.

MIKE
Ronald Kistler, as I live and breathe.

Mike mocks fanning himself and gives Ron a big hug.

MIKE (CONT'D)
How's she holding up?

RON
You can't beat NASA-grade construction. That's the technology that faked a moon landing.

MIKE
Mine's already a mess.

RON
I've seen your tent, that doesn't surprise me.

Dalton joins them, shoving a hamburger in his mouth like he hasn't eaten in months.

MIKE
Dalton? How the hell are you doing?

DALTON
Still living at home.

Dalton's Mom shouts from behind them.

DALTON'S MOM
Did you give them the muffins?

DALTON
Not yet, ma.

Dalton hands them each a muffin.

DALTON (CONT'D)
But it sure beats prison. And I enrolled.

RON
Back in the military?

DALTON
After all that time I hope you would know me better. I signed up for classes. I gotta take drug counseling as part of my plea deal and I'm actually digging it. Start college in the fall to become a counselor.

RON
Good for you.

Mike rolls a cooler out of his truck and starts handing around beers. The three men take seats side by side in lawn chairs, facing the trailer, sitting in their same billboard positions almost out of habit.

DALTON
So after all that... was it worth it? All of this for a year of your life?

Ron takes a long pause and stares at Sue, laughing with her friends and family as she shows them around the home.

RON
Absolutely.

They clink bottles and stare in silence at the home. Their chairs settled into the dirt. The lot is muddy with the trailer resting uneasily in the center.

It may not be everybody's idea of perfect, and most people may look down on it, but it's home. And in the end that's all these guys ever wanted.

GENE WERLEY (O.S.)
This is Early Werley here with some financial news. America's number one scourge, unemployment, is on the rise again for the fifth consecutive month in a row.

EXT. APARTMENT COMPLEX - DAY

The complex is a sprawl of low-end tenement housing. Peeling paint, a couple old external air conditioning units, drying sheets hanging from windows.

GENE WERLEY (O.S.)
And while the times may be tough out there, remember that this is America where fortunes can change in an instant. This is the land of opportunity...

Ron looks over at the radio.

GENE WERLEY (O.S.) (CONT'D)
... An opportunity to win a brand new thirty-six-inch color TV from Stan's Electronics. All you have to do to enter this exclusive WSAN contes--

Ron switches the radio off.

We pull back as Ron paints the empty apartment, a smile on his face as he enjoys the silence. A large sign outside the complex reads 'Fulmer Apartments.' To most people this would be a constant reminder that no matter how hard you try you will always be working for the 1%.

But to Ron it's nothing but a reminder of his victory over the people who tried to control him. And he would have it no other way.

FADE OUT